



PLANNING STATEMENT FULL PLANNING SUBMISSION

BASMA - BELMONT AND SUTTON MUSLIM ASSEMBLY
The Proposed Change Of The Former Sutton Ambulance Station
(Planning Use Class Sui Generis) To A Community Hub With Prayer Facility
(Planning Use Class F1 & F2)
At: Dorset Road, Sutton, SM2 6JH

Atelier | U W A Chartered Architects Ltd



PLANNING STATEMENT FOR:

The Proposed Change Of The Former Sutton Ambulance Station [Planning Use Class Sui Generis] To A Community Hub With Prayer Facility [Planning Use Class F.1 & F.2]
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PLANNING STATEMENT

Executive Summary

This Planning Statement supports the applicant's Full Planning submission for the Change of Use of the former Sutton Ambulance Station, Dorset Road, Belmont (Use Class Sui Generis), into a mixed-use **Community Hub and Place of Worship** (Use Classes F.1 and F.2), to be delivered by the **Belmont and Sutton Muslim Assembly (BASMA)**. The proposal responds to demonstrable and rising community need, aligned with demographic trends and supported by robust evidence of demand for local, inclusive, and faith-sensitive infrastructure within the Belmont Ward.

The site, comprising approximately 0.12 hectares of previously developed brownfield land, is currently vacant and surplus to NHS operational requirements. It lies within a predominantly residential neighbourhood but benefits from existing social infrastructure in the vicinity — including schools, a church, a care home, and public transport routes. The proposal includes the **adaptive reuse** of the existing structure, **modest single-storey extension**, and **external greening and access upgrades**.

The proposed development will:

- Provide a **permanent base** for spiritual, social, educational, and interfaith activities
- Introduce dedicated facilities for **women, elderly users, and families** currently underserved by existing provision
- Reduce pressure on over-capacity religious centres elsewhere in the borough.
- Promote **active travel**, inclusive access, and modal shift via well-connected walking routes and hail-and-ride bus services.
- Deliver biodiversity uplift and **urban greening** measures in line with BNG obligations and Policy 26 & 33 of the Sutton Local Plan.

Since the pre-application stage (Ref. PRE2025/00079), the design has evolved in response to the London Borough of Sutton's feedback and through collaboration with a full technical team.

The following reports and updates are now incorporated into this full submission:

- Transport & Highways: *Caneparo Associates – Transport Statement & Travel Plan* confirm that site access and circulation operate safely within existing highway geometry. The scheme provides 14 car spaces (including 2 accessible and 2 EV-ready bays) and 8 cycle stands, consistent with London Plan Policies T5 and T6 and Sutton Policies 35–37. Peak-hour trip generation is forecast to remain below former ambulance-station levels. A package of measures—including staggered prayer sessions, volunteer traffic marshals, on-site parking management, car-share promotion, and active-travel

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incentives—forms the basis of the approved Travel Plan (refer to report for full details).

- Flood Risk & Drainage: *Unda Consulting – Flood Risk & Drainage Assessment* introducing partial SuDS betterment through permeable paving and a below-ground raingarden.
- Biodiversity Net Gain: *BNG Report* confirming measurable ecological enhancement (refer to report for full compliance & mitigation assessment).
- Energy & Sustainability: *Syntegra Consulting – Energy Strategy* confirming compliance with Part L 2021 Volume 2 through improved building fabric, ASHP heating, and potential PV integration.
- Water Efficiency: *Syntegra Consulting – Water Efficiency Statement* demonstrating water-saving measures consistent with BREEAM Wat 01 guidance.
- Noise Impact & Amenity: *Hann Tucker* confirming internal acoustic mitigation and appropriate hours of operation.

Please refer to Appendix B ‘Response to London Borough of Sutton’s Pre-Application Feedback [Ref: PRE2025/00079]’

Collectively, these studies [and the summary assessment to be found in Appendix B], confirm that the proposal meets all validation and technical requirements raised by the Council’s pre-app feedback. The design embodies London Plan Policies D3, SI1, SI2, SI13 and Sutton Local Plan Policies 28, 31, 32, and 33, promoting inclusive infrastructure, biodiversity net gain, and sustainable transport integration.

The proposal achieves enhanced walkability, improved access, and urban greening, while securing a contextually balanced built form that complements its residential surroundings. With robust demographic justification, strong local partnerships, and detailed operational planning, the project is both policy-compliant and socially grounded, delivering a resilient, low-carbon community facility for Sutton residents.

The proposal is fully **policy-compliant**, demonstrating consistency with:

- Sutton Local Plan (Policies 1, 22, 26, 28, 29, 31, 33, 34, 35, 36, 37, 43).
- London Plan 2021 (Policies GG1, GG2, D3, S1, T5, T6).
- NPPF 2023/24 (Chapters 2, 8, 9, 11, and 12).
- Sutton SPDs on Urban Design, Transport & Sustainable Construction.

A clear operational management strategy, including **staggered peak use**, low impact design, sound insulation upgrades, and onsite cycle and refuse facilities, ensures that the scheme protects residential amenity while enhancing local social infrastructure.

The application represents a proportionate, inclusive, and sustainable community use for a dormant public asset — directly aligned with local and national planning objectives for neighbourhood cohesion, equitable service access, and urban resilience.

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1.0 Introduction

This Planning Statement has been prepared in support of a proposal by the Belmont and Sutton Muslim Assembly (BASMA) a registered charity, to secure planning permission for the Change of Use of the former ambulance station on Dorset Road, Belmont, Sutton.

The site, comprising previously developed brownfield land, was most recently in Sui Generis use as an ambulance station. The proposal seeks a material Change of Use to a mixed-use community facility comprising:

- Place of Worship (Use Class F.1(f)), and
- Community Centre (Use Class F.2(b))

1.1 BASMA is a locally rooted charity supported by a dedicated team of trustees and volunteers. Its mission is to meet the spiritual, educational, and social needs of the Muslim community in Belmont and adjacent areas within this part of Sutton. Over recent years, BASMA has worked in close partnership with local churches, schools, voluntary organisations, and residents to support faith-sensitive, inclusive community development.

1.2 The vision is to establish a permanent, dignified, and inclusive base for BASMA's activities. At present, only Friday prayer services are delivered from rented space at the local St John's Community Hall [a seven-minute walking distance from the application site]. This limits the organisation's ability to offer broader community programmes. The proposed facility will provide continuity of service and create a locally accessible, drop-in point, including for the wider community.

1.3 The proposed scheme will:

- Provide a permanent base for daily and Friday congregational prayers
- Deliver a wide range of inclusive services such as youth mentoring, elderly support, interfaith dialogue, family engagement, and educational programming
- Sensitively reuse an underutilised civic site with modest physical alterations to bring the internal to habitable grade use.
- Operate under a clear and transparent management plan, ensuring that activities remain respectful of surrounding residential character

1.4 This Planning Statement provides a structured and policy-grounded justification for the proposed Change of Use and includes:

- A description of the site and surrounding planning context
- A detailed explanation of the proposed development and operational model
- An evidence-led case for community need and local demographic alignment
- A review of the relevant planning policy framework, including the NPPF (2023), London Plan, and Sutton Local Plan
- A concluding planning balance showing that the proposal delivers clear public benefit, policy compliance, and sustainable reuse

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The proposal is submitted as a low-impact, high-benefit community use, and it is respectfully requested that the Council view it favourably in accordance with local and national policy objectives.

1.5 This document is to be read in conjunction with the following Architects' Drawings and Documentation:

Drawings:

- 786-BASMA-SU-100-EXISTING GROUND FLOOR AND BIRD-EYE ROOF PLAN,
- SITE OS LOCATION PLAN AND BLOCK PLAN
- 786-BASMA-SU-101-EXISTING NORTH, WEST, SOUTH & EAST ELEVATIONS AND SECTIONS
- 786-BASMA-SU-102-EXISTING BUILDING 3D VIEWS
- 786-BASMA-PL-200-PROPOSED SITE LAYOUT PLAN, SITE LOCATION PLAN & BLOCK PLAN
- 786-BASMA-PL-201-PROPOSED GROUND FLOOR PLAN AND 3D VIEW
- 786-BASMA-PL-202-MATERIAL ELEVATION A AND MATERIAL ELEVATION B
- 786-BASMA-PL-203-PROPOSED NORTH, WEST, SOUTH & EAST ELEVATIONS
- 786-BASMA-PL-204-PROPOSED SECTIONS
- TPP-01 – TREE CONSTRAINTS PLAN TREE PROTECTION PLAN, Rev -A

Documents:

- The DAS [Design & Access Statement], produced by Atelier | U W A Architects Ltd
- The Transport Statement, produced by Caneparo Associates, Transport Consultant
- The Travel Plan, produced by Caneparo Associates, Transport Consultant
- The Outline Construction Logistic Plan, produced by Caneparo Associates, Transport Consultant
- The Delivery and Servicing Management Plan, produced by Caneparo Associates, Transport Consultant
- The Parking Plan, produced by Innowise Work, Transport Consultant
- The Fire Strategy Statement Report, produced by ATC Fire Safety, Fire Consultant
- The Environmental Noise Survey and Noise Impact Assessment Report produced by Hann Tucker Associates, Acoustics Consultant
- The Flood Risk Assessment and Surface Water Drainage Strategy Report produced by UNDA Consulting, Flood Consultant
- The Biodiversity Net Gain Assessment produced by Arbtech Consulting, Ecological Consultant
- The Statutory Biodiversity Metric produced by Arbtech Consulting, Ecological Consultant
- The Energy Strategy Report produced by Syntegra Consulting, Energy Consultant
- The Water Efficiency Report produced by Syntegra Consulting, Energy Consultant
- The BRUKL Output Document produced by Syntegra Consulting, Energy Consultant
- The Tree Protection Plan produced by Arbor Cultural Limited, Arbor culturalist
- The Tree survey and report, Impact Assessment, Method Statements produced by Arbor Cultural Limited, Arbor culturalist

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2.0 Site Location and Planning Context

The application site comprises the former ambulance station located on Dorset Road, Belmont, Sutton, situated within a predominantly residential neighbourhood in the London Borough of Sutton.

While the area is predominantly residential in character, it is supported by a range of established social infrastructure, including St John's Church and Community Hall (approximately 150 metres away), many nursing homes in the area, and several educational institutions such as Avenue Primary Academy, Harris Academy Sutton and Overton Grange School within a short walking distance. The presence of these facilities demonstrates that the area accommodates diverse community and civic uses in addition to housing.

The site lies approximately 500 metres from Belmont Station, and access to and from the site is well served by the S2 & S4 bus routes, offering good access to local public transport. The application site is within convenient walking distance of Belmont High Street, which provides neighbourhood-level services and amenities.

The availability of hail-and-ride services between regulated bus stops supports flexible, car-free access options and reinforces the scheme's low transport impact profile.

The application site is only seven minutes walking distance from BASMA's temporary prayer facility at St Johns Community Hall [where Friday prayers are held].

In this way the site location and use have sustainable transport credentials and tangible benefits. The hail-and-ride service is a valuable feature that directly enhances **walkability and sustainable access**, particularly for:

- Elderly users
- Women with children
- Those unable to walk the full distance
- Local residents in low-car households

These sustainability credentials are further strengthened by the findings of a recent transport survey, which confirms that a significant proportion of attendees currently access Friday prayers at the nearby St John's Community Hall on foot. The modal split analysis clearly supports the site's suitability for walkable, low-impact community use in line with active travel and sustainable transport objectives.

2.1 Site Characteristics

The Building:

The Entrance to the site does not face any residential neighbourhood properties, neither their entrances nor habitat / amenity areas.

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The building comprises a single-storey brick & block-built structure, with extensive use of ceramic, glazed tile cladding previously used as an ambulance station (Sui Generis). The building is flat-roofed, modest in massing height, and set back from the road behind a forecourt area laid to hardstanding, which historically served as a vehicle apron and staff parking. The building occupies approximately 0.3 acres (0.12 hectares) and is now vacant and surplus to NHS operational requirements.

The existing structure was originally designed and constructed as an ambulance depot with associated staff and service areas. The main construction elements include:

- **External walls:** solid 13-inch-thick loadbearing masonry, clad in ceramic tiles in a vertical stack bond pattern, with no thermal insulation
- **Roof construction:** flat, lightweight build-up comprising wood wool slabs with a cementitious binder, finished in bituminous felt, supported by castellated steel beams and galvanised steel joists
- **Internal walls:** predominantly single-skin masonry (~100mm) with some structural elements at 215mm
- **Floors:** ground-bearing in-situ concrete slab, reinforced in the garage area to support heavier loading, with slight gradient toward the apron; ancillary office areas are slightly raised by approx. +150mm, and no thermal insulation is assumed in the floor build-up

The structure includes a number of large industrial garage doors that stack laterally, a legacy of its operational function as an ambulance depot.

The site:

The building is set back from the road behind a forecourt area currently laid to hardstanding, which previously served as a vehicle apron and staff parking. There is soft landscaping to the front amenity and west, side boundary. With good visual screening of shrubs, hedging and trees to the north, west and east boundary.

- The site is rectangular in shape and bounded by a low wall and fencing
- It includes a side and rear yard, allowing for service access and secure cycle storage
- Existing site access is taken directly from Dorset Road, a residential street
- The site currently accommodates approximately 10–12 on-site car parking spaces

The building has been vacant for some time and is now surplus to operational healthcare requirements.

The site offers a suitable footprint for adaptive reuse, and the proposed single-storey extension will sensitively accommodate additional space for women's use, accessible washrooms, and ancillary facilities such as a kitchen and kitchenette to support the wider community programme.

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The existing layout, combined with the proposed additions, provides sufficient capacity and access arrangements to support a low-impact, inclusive community facility.

2.2 Surrounding Context

The Entrance to the site does not directly face any residential neighbourhood properties, neither their entrances nor habitat / amenity areas.

The surrounding area is characterised by:

- Substantial, Three-storey residential dwellings to the east as adjoining blocks of flats under duo-pitch roofs. There is no direct overlooking to the adjacent single storey garages or parking area.
- Substantial Two-storey residential dwellings to the west as detached Edwardian villa style properties
- To the north aspect of the site are the lawned bowling greens of Sutton Bowling Club. The application site does not directly overlook the expansive club building.
- Avenue Primary Academy and local retail facilities nearby
- St John's Church within walking distance — a current partner location for temporary prayer hire by BASMA
- The site is within a 15-minute neighbourhood setting, consistent with emerging strategic planning objectives to enable access to essential community infrastructure within walking or cycling distance. This principle is embedded in the London Plan 2021 (Policies GG2 and SD6) and supported by Sutton Local Plan Policy 1, which encourages compact, inclusive neighbourhoods with local access to civic and social uses such as places of worship, schools, and community centres.

No part of the site lies within a conservation area, and the building is not listed. The surrounding land uses are predominantly residential but interspersed with civic, educational, and healthcare infrastructure, including other former NHS assets

The Burton Estate Special Character Area lies over 1 kilometre north-east of the application site and has no direct visual or contextual relationship to the proposal. The site on Dorset Road is not within or adjacent to any designated special character or conservation area, and therefore the development will not affect the setting or significance of any such designations.

2.3 Planning Baseline and Land Use Designation

According to the **Sutton Local Plan Policies Map**, the site is:

- Located within the **urban area**
- Not subject to any **site-specific policy allocation**
- Not located within a **flood risk zone**
- **Previously developed (brownfield) land**, making it a suitable candidate for efficient reuse under the NPPF

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The building's former use as an operational ambulance station establishes a precedent for public service use and frequent, vehicular activity. In this context, the proposed use as a place of worship and community centre represents a comparable and potentially lower-impact civic use, subject to appropriate controls.

Land Use Designation:

The site is classified as **previously developed brownfield land**, and its former Sui Generis use as an ambulance station confirms its historical status as a public service asset.

This planning baseline supports the **principle of change of use**, particularly where it contributes to borough-wide infrastructure objectives under Local Plan **Policy 1 (Sustainable Growth)** and **Policy 22 (Social and Community Infrastructure)**.

3.0 The Proposed Development

The application seeks planning permission for the Change of Use of the former ambulance station on Dorset Road, Belmont, from its previous Sui Generis use (ambulance depot) to a mixed-use community facility comprising:

- **Place of Worship (Use Class F.1(f))**, and
- **Community Centre (Use Class F.2(b))**

The proposal involves the adaptive reuse of the existing building and a modest single-storey extension to the north, enabling the provision of a dedicated female prayer and multi-use area, accessible toilets, ablution areas, and a kitchen. The main structure will house the central male prayer hall, with additional flexible-use spaces on the south side of the site. Modest external works will also include resurfacing, enhanced boundary treatments, and provision of cycle storage and refuse facilities.

The scheme preserves the low-rise civic scale of the building while improving its function, accessibility, and long-term social value.

Urban Greening:

A detailed Preliminary Biodiversity Net Gain Statement, confirming the site's alignment with the Environment Act 2021 and Small Sites Metric (SSM) requirements, is provided in **Appendix B**

To enhance biodiversity and visual amenity, vertical trellising with climbing plants will be introduced along key façades to soften the building's utilitarian appearance and contribute to Sutton's urban greening objectives. This low-impact intervention supports the principles of **Policy 33 (Climate Change Adaptation)** and aligns with the Council's **Urban Greening Factor** aspirations by delivering enhanced microclimate performance, increased ecological value, and improved integration within the residential streetscape.

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3.1 Internal Layout and Facilities

The proposed layout includes:

- A main central prayer hall (former garage)
- A multi-purpose and contemplation hall (south side, existing structure)
- A female prayer and multi-use area (north side, proposed extension)
- Accessible toilets, ablution areas, and a kitchen
- An imam's office / small meeting room
- Front garden and verge landscaping
- External cycle storage for 8+ bicycles
- On-site parking for 10-12 vehicles + 2 accessible bays

3.2 Proposed Activities

The facility will accommodate a range of **community-focused uses**, reflecting BASMA's charitable aims and the needs of the local population. These include:

- Daily and Friday congregational prayers
- Supplementary education and homework support for school-age children
- Ladies' keep fit and wellbeing sessions
- Counselling and bereavement support for men, women, and families
- Interfaith coffee mornings and neighbourhood drop-ins
- Seniors' lunch club and walking group
- Men's and youth fitness sessions
- Girls' and women's social and mentoring activities
- Health and wellbeing surgeries (e.g. diabetes, heart health, smoking cessation)
- Community information events and multi-faith gatherings
- A publicly accessible defibrillator on site

These activities are programmed throughout the week and will be operated on a rotating, time-specific basis, with modest attendance levels and active supervision by BASMA volunteers.

3.3 Hours of Operation

Proposed operational hours:

- Community Use: Monday to Sunday: 7:00 AM – 10:00 PM
- Prayer Use varies according to the solar cycle upto 11.00 PM

3.4 Parking and Access

The existing forecourt will provide:

- 10-12 general car parking spaces
- 2 accessible bays
- Secure, sheltered cycle parking for 8+ bicycles

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- Safe pedestrian access from Dorset Road
- Provision for passive EV charging infrastructure (future-ready)

3.5 Low-Impact and Sustainable Reuse

The development will:

- Retain the existing footprint with a modest extension
- Allow for structural alterations and infilling
- Improve site security and amenity through passive surveillance
- Promote active travel and healthy lifestyles
- Deliver a clear public benefit through inclusive, accessible community infrastructure

3.6 User friendly access to and from the application site

- Both the S2 and S4 bus routes that serve the site operate a hail-and-ride service along their Belmont routes.
- This flexible system allows passengers to board and alight between fixed stops, offering exceptional convenience for those walking part of the way to the site.
- The ability to combine walking with a short hail-and-ride segment supports inclusive access, particularly for older residents, parents with young children, and users with reduced mobility.
- The availability of hail-and-ride enhances the site's compatibility with Sutton's sustainable movement strategy and the London Plan's Healthy Streets objectives, by reducing dependency on car use while still enabling access for a broad user base.

4.0 Justification for Community Need and Operational Constraints

The proposed development responds directly to an identified local infrastructure gap and longstanding operational challenges faced by the Muslim community in Belmont and the surrounding area. At present, BASMA rents space at St John's Community Hall for Friday (Jumma) congregational prayers. While this arrangement has been a valued temporary solution, it remains inherently limited, insecure, and unsustainable for meeting the community's broader spiritual, educational, and wellbeing needs.

The applicant wishes to express sincere appreciation to St John's Church for its ongoing support and hospitality. However, the current use of the hall is subject to significant constraints:

- **Restricted access:** Availability is limited to Fridays only, which prevents the delivery of daily prayers and wider community-based programming such as youth mentoring, seniors' wellbeing, or educational workshops.
- **Inconsistent availability including for Friday prayers :** There have been instances where key prayer sessions were **cancelled or displaced** due to

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double bookings or venue conflicts, undermining the stability and routine of the congregation.

- **Inadequate facilities:** The current venue **lacks dedicated on-site parking** and cycle infrastructure, which disproportionately impacts **elderly residents, families with children**, and those with **mobility challenge**

Need for a Permanent, Local, Community Scale, Facility

BASMA are the only service provider catering for the needs of the Muslim community within the Belmont ward.

At present, because BASMA only has limited use of St John's Hall on Fridays, the local community are frequently required to attend other Centres throughout Sutton for daily prayers or structured community activities, **to the extent they are available, at these other community hubs**. These include:

-Sutton Central Masjid, 25 Carshalton Rd, Sutton SM1 4LF [1.6miles away which is a 33-minute walking distance]

-Sutton Islamic Centre, 62 Oakhill Rd, Sutton SM1 3AG [2.2miles away which is a 47-minute walking distance]

-Muslim Cultural & Welfare Association of Sutton (MCWAS), Wentworth Hall, 80 Ruskin Road, Carshalton, Surrey, SM5 3DH [2.7miles away which is a 58-minute walking distance]

This reliance places **additional, unsustainable pressure on those centres** — serving their own local catchment, many of which are already at or near capacity — and increases dependency on car travel, contrary to sustainable access goals. By providing a local, walkable facility in Belmont, the proposed development will reduce unnecessary car trips, encourage active travel, and alleviate pressure on facilities elsewhere in the borough. This provides access to varied community facilities under one roof.

In addition, the proposed centre will meaningfully address the current **lack of provision for women** that exists in the temporary arrangements. St John's Hall does not offer a separate, safe space for women and girls to participate in daily community activities tailored to their needs. The proposed scheme provides **a dedicated and dignified space for women — a key principle in inclusive, culturally responsive community infrastructure**.

The proposed Change of Use would address these needs and operational constraints, by providing BASMA with a dedicated, well-managed centre. They would have a permanent base to deliver a consistent programme of services that directly responds to local needs, including:

- **Daily and Friday prayers** in a suitable, acoustically contained space
- **Supplementary education and youth mentoring**
- **Women & Men's fitness, social activities, and counselling support**

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- **Seniors' wellbeing groups and social drop-ins**
- **Interfaith engagement** through inclusive community events and information mornings
- **Health and wellbeing advice**, including outreach on diabetes, heart health, smoking cessation and mental health.

These services are not currently available in a coordinated or accessible format for the local Muslim population and their families, many of whom live within walking distance of the site.

Need in relation to the demographics of the locality

-The Belmont Ward also has a significantly higher proportion of Muslim residents than the borough average (**9.4%** vs. 7%), with ongoing demographic change continuing to drive the need for accessible, locally based faith, cultural and community centre, based infrastructure.

-In 2021, 17.5% of Sutton residents identified their ethnic group within the "Asian, Asian British or Asian Welsh" category, this is up from 11.6% in 2011. The 6.0% percentage-point change was the largest increase among high-level ethnic groups in this area.

For the Belmont ward the percentage point change [increase] is 10.8%

The detailed demographic evidence supporting this application is provided in **Appendix A – Belmont Ward Demographic Summary**, which outlines the ward's significantly higher Muslim population, ethnic diversity, and increasing youth and family-based needs. This data reinforces the proposal's alignment with the Borough's strategic aims for inclusive and equitable community infrastructure provision.

Suitability of the Dorset Road Site

The Dorset Road site is ideally suited to deliver this community provision:

- It is a previously developed brownfield site with a history of public service use
- Located in a quiet, accessible location within a 15-minute neighbourhood setting
- Capable of accommodating:
 - On-site car parking (approximately 10–12 spaces including disabled bays)
 - Secure cycle storage
 - Modest internal reconfiguration and modest extension to support inclusive access and flexibility of use

This transition to a dedicated facility will enable BASMA to serve its community seven days a week, within agreed hours of operation, and in a way that enhances

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neighbourhood integration and supports borough-wide goals for inclusive, low-impact infrastructure reuse.

This inclusive approach aligns with the Council's commitment under the **Equality Act 2010**, supports **Policy 43 (Equality and Inclusion)** of the Sutton Local Plan, and contributes to borough-wide objectives to promote inclusive social infrastructure and cultural cohesion.

5.0 Planning Policy Context

This section sets out an assessment of the proposed development against the relevant planning policy framework at **local**, **regional**, and **national** levels. It also considers the implications of relevant **Supplementary Planning Documents (SPDs)** and technical guidance issued by the London Borough of Sutton.

This assessment demonstrates that the proposed Change of Use and associated works are policy-compliant, delivering a sustainable, inclusive, and low-impact community facility that responds to identified need and brings a long-vacant civic site back into active use.

We have considered the following planning policy documents:

- Local Development Plan Policies including SPD's & Technical Guidance documentation on sustainability and Biodiversity
- London Wide Planning Policies – the London Plan
- National Planning Policies – The NPPF [National Planning Policy Framework]

Local Development Plan Policies

5.1 The Sutton Local Plan (Adopted February 2018)

The Sutton Local Plan 2018 is the principal statutory development plan for the London Borough of Sutton. It was formally adopted on 28 February 2018 following independent examination and replaces the former Core Strategy and Site Development Policies. The Plan sets out the Council's spatial vision, strategic objectives, and detailed land use policies to guide development in the borough over a 15-year period to 2031.

The Local Plan is used to assess all planning applications in Sutton and is afforded full weight under Section 38(6) of the Planning and Compulsory Purchase Act

2004, which states that decisions should be made in accordance with the development plan unless material considerations indicate otherwise.

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The Plan comprises strategic policies, development management policies, and site allocations, and is supported by a number of Supplementary Planning Documents (SPDs) and technical guidance notes. It is structured around the themes of sustainable growth, design, infrastructure, environmental resilience, housing, economy, and community well-being, and reflects both national planning policy and the broader objectives of the London Plan.

This Planning Statement provides a detailed assessment of the proposed development against the relevant policies of the Sutton Local Plan, demonstrating that the Change of Use and associated extension is compliant with the strategic and operational planning framework for the borough.

5.2 Evidence for Need: Community Demand, Demographics & Infrastructure Pressure

Source: Sutton Local Plan (Adopted 2018)

5.2-a. Population Growth and Infrastructure Pressure

"Community facilities such as health, schools and sports and leisure centres are a very important part of the social infrastructure... These facilities are under pressure from cutbacks in public funding and from the impact of continuing population growth and development... physical infrastructure will remain the main method in which the majority of these services can be accessed."

(Policy 22: Social and Community Infrastructure – Facts and Trends)

This directly supports the point that community infrastructure, including places of worship and multi-purpose spaces, face increasing demand due to **ongoing demographic change**. In addition, the local catchment area has a higher Muslim population than the rest of Sutton, further supporting the fact a local community space is required.

5.2-b. Council's Acknowledgement of Growth-Driven Need

"Developments can lead to increased pressure on Sutton's existing community facilities and infrastructure, either cumulatively or individually... The council will look at the likely number of future occupants... existing facilities accessible to the development and their capacity."

(Policy 22.2: Social and Community Infrastructure)

This confirms the **policy expectation that community needs assessments** are relevant to development planning, especially when proposing to increase capacity in areas like Belmont.

5.2-c. Infrastructure Study as a Supporting Document

"An 'Infrastructure Study' has been prepared as background evidence to the Local Plan. It sets out details on the key infrastructure schemes... to complement growth

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over the Local Plan period.”

(Policy 38: Infrastructure Delivery – Facts and Trends)

This supports the broader claim that the borough **monitors and identifies infrastructure gaps**. The Local Plan cites it as **key to evidence-based planning**.

5.2-d. Demographic Snapshot in the Local Plan’s Monitoring Framework

“The population is increasing. The number of households is increasing. The number of school-age children is increasing.”

(Chapter 2: Challenges, Vision and Objectives – Headline Trends)

These are critical indicators justifying faith-based, youth, and family-oriented infrastructure like that proposed at the Belmont site.

In summary:

“The Sutton Local Plan identifies continued population growth, increasing household formation, and rising pressure on community infrastructure as major planning challenges. Policy 22 and supporting facts recognise a borough-wide shortage of flexible, accessible community space. These pressures validate the proposed development as a response to demographic change and unmet local need.”
(Citing: Policies 22 and 38; Monitoring Report; Infrastructure Study Reference)

Policy 1 – Sustainable Growth

Relevant Objective: Delivering sustainable development through balanced growth in homes, employment, and infrastructure. The policy references the need for Sutton’s growth to be inclusive and balanced, not just in terms of homes and jobs, but in community provision.

Compliance Justification:

BASMA’s proposal contributes to social infrastructure provision by meeting a specific religious and cultural need within the Belmont area, which is underserved in terms of accessible Muslim prayer and community facilities.

It repurposes an existing, disused site within a developed residential area, making efficient use of land.

It does not conflict with identified housing growth areas and will serve the existing and growing population in a sustainable, low-impact way.

The community hall, interfaith events, and multi-use space promote local resilience, social cohesion, and integration, in line with the sustainability aims of this policy.

- Elderly luncheon programmes.
- Mothers and toddler’s support.
- Space for people to learn, play and connect.

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Policy 22 – Social and Community Infrastructure

Purpose: To protect and support development of facilities that meet community needs.

Compliance Justification:

This facility directly supports the multi-faith, multi-generational needs of the Belmont area, addressing unmet demand and replacing unreliable rented access at the nearby St John's Hall.

The proposed Change of Use increases provision of inclusive services without loss of other social infrastructure.

Community hire of space and programmes for youth, toddlers, and elderly users further embed the facility as local infrastructure, satisfying Policy 22(a)–(c)

The scheme specifically supports **gender-inclusive provision** by allocating safe spaces for women and girls.

Policy 43 – Equality and Inclusion

Objective: Support equality of opportunity, inclusive design, and reduce social inequality.

Compliance Justification:

- The proposed use directly supports religious minorities and underserved demographics.
- The project has been carefully designed to meet the needs of **all user groups**, including women, children, youth and elderly participants. The inclusion of spaces and programming specifically for these vulnerable groups responds directly to known access barriers and cultural expectations, reinforcing the proposal's alignment with Sutton's wider equality and social cohesion objectives.
- It will provide free or low-cost access to social programmes.
- The facility will be step-free and fully accessible to those with physical disabilities.
- The project fosters faith cohesion and contributes to Sutton's duties under the Equality Act 2010 and Public Sector Equality Duty (PSED).

Conclusion on Community Need and Demographic Support

- This proposal is a direct and measured response to emerging demographic trends in Belmont Ward and the wider borough.
- It prevents marginalisation by giving a stable home to faith and cultural activities currently displaced across the borough.

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- The scheme specifically supports **gender-inclusive provision** by allocating distinct but equal-use spaces for women and girls, which is a recognised shortfall in current local infrastructure. This enables safe, dignified, and culturally appropriate participation in social and religious activities, in accordance with the policy's emphasis on accessibility and inclusivity.
- It is fully policy-compliant with Sutton's Local Plan (Policies 1, 21, 22, and 43), and should be regarded as delivering critical infrastructure in the form of a modest, well-located, multi-purpose community asset.

Policy 28 – Character and Design

Purpose: To ensure development is high quality, contextual, and sensitive to local character. Requires development to respond to context, scale, and massing, while contributing positively to the street and neighbouring amenity.

Compliance Justification:

The proposed single-storey rear extension is proportionate, low in visual impact, and complements the scale and materials of the existing building.

It is set back from all boundaries, and subordinate in form.

- There is a slight increase in building height as it would be advantageous to have higher ceilings within the community and prayer hall.
- No new windows overlooking adjacent properties.
- Material selection and fenestration will be sympathetic to the host building and streetscape.
- Refuse and servicing will be managed discreetly onsite, avoiding amenity or public realm issues.
- The development will incorporate **Secured by Design Principles** as set out in the accompanying DAS, supporting the objectives of NPPF para. 97 and Sutton Local Plan Policy 28

Urban greening is proposed including to the existing external fabric to the main elevations, enhancing the street scene whilst largely respecting the massing height of the existing built form.

The same **modest and sympathetic design approach** will be taken to ensure the building does not appear visually incongruous or overly assertive within its setting. Materials, detailing, and finishes will be carefully selected from a **sensitive and restrained palette**, complementing the established architectural rhythm and surrounding context.

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Use at busy periods such as Friday prayer would be managed via programming (e.g., staggered Friday prayers), minimising any visual or functional overdevelopment concerns.

Policy 29 – Protecting Amenity

Purpose: To prevent adverse impacts on surrounding occupiers. Ensure that new development does not cause an unacceptable loss of amenity to existing or future occupiers, especially in terms of noise, activity levels, overlooking, loss of privacy, or visual intrusion.

Compliance Justification:

A key part of the operational management strategy involves staggered event and prayer times, especially on Fridays, to avoid conflicts with local traffic and school runs.

On-site parking and disabled bays ensure local streets are not pressured.

Internal soundproofing and use restrictions (hours of operation) can be agreed through planning conditions to preserve residential amenity.

Baseline Use Context: The site was most recently used as an **ambulance station**, a Sui Generis use involving:

- 24-hour operation potential.
- Blue-light vehicle movements.
- Shift-based staffing with vehicular noise.
- Medical waste or clinical operations.

This context **sets a precedent for operational use**, traffic, and service activity within the area, particularly in terms of:

- Vehicle comings and goings
- Noise associated with emergency operations
- Late-night/early-morning staff activity
- **Proposed Use Characteristics:**
 - Place of worship and community centre use class (F.1 & F.2).
 - Five daily prayers (the proposed timetable of uses in the DAS show that these are small gatherings).
 - Friday congregational prayer (main weekly peak).

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- Intermittent daytime community use: youth clubs, toddlers' play, homework support, social events.
- **Amenity Management Proposals:**
 - **Staggered Friday prayers** explicitly timed to avoid school run overlap.
 - **Community use programming** mainly during daytime or early evening hours.
 - **No amplified outdoor noise** or outdoor public address systems.
 - Potential for **sound insulation upgrades** within the existing building fabric.
 - **Events management plan** can limit late-night or high impact uses.
 - The rear extension is single-storey and will **not introduce overlooking** or overshadowing issues due to its scale and siting.

Assessment Summary:

- The new use, while of a different nature, is arguably of lower intensity and impact than the previous ambulance operations.
- Proposed activities are managed through programming, resulting in limited impacts on neighbouring amenity.
- Design elements and operational practices address Policy 29(a)-(d), ensuring:
 - Minimal noise.
 - No light pollution
 - No loss of privacy.
 - Controlled hours of use
 - Appropriate boundary treatment and screening.

Conclusion on Amenity and Neighbour Impact

- The proposal is **policy-compliant** with Sutton's amenity protection standards.
- It presents a **lower noise and movement profile** than the prior Sui Generis ambulance station uses.
- Appropriate design and **operational strategies mitigate amenity concerns**, and full details can be provided in supporting reports (e.g., Statement of Use, Operational Management Plan).
- Opportunities for **soft boundary landscaping** could further enhance screening and residential interface.

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Policy 31 – Carbon and Energy

Purpose: Ensure development meets energy performance and carbon reduction targets.

Compliance Justification:

While the scheme is a minor non-residential development, and thus not subject to the 35% or zero-carbon thresholds for major development, the applicant proposes:

- LED lighting and efficient HVAC systems in refurbished areas.
- Exploring use of solar PV panels or passive solar design in the rear extension.
- Use of insulation in roof/walls to enhance thermal performance.
A basic Energy Statement can be submitted to demonstrate compliance with Part L of the Building Regulations, and voluntary carbon reduction can align with the carbon offset guidance in the Technical Note (April 2018) if appropriate.
- Water conservation measures on all taps: use of flow restrictors; use of non-concussive taps with automatic shut-off
- Water conservation measures for WC's: dual low volume flush

Policy 33 – Climate Change Adaptation

Purpose: To reduce vulnerability to climate impacts and increase urban greening.

Compliance Justification:

The proposal includes surface water drainage considerations, and potential for increased green landscaping.

Opportunities exist to include permeable paving, (if viable), and tree planting—helping meet the Green Space Factor encouraged under the Technical Guidance Note.

This aligns with the borough's One Planet Strategy and Policy 33(b)'s focus on sustainable site layout.

Sustainability Integration Summary

The development demonstrates strong compliance with the Local Plan's sustainability policies by:

- Promoting **low-carbon reuse** of an existing building.

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- Delivering a **climate-resilient and socially inclusive facility**.
- Managing water and drainage responsibly.
- Avoiding environmental harm.
- Enabling **modal shift** (walking, cycling, local transport).
- Both the S2 and S4 bus routes that serve the site operate a hail-and-ride service along their Belmont routes.
- **The ability to combine walking with a short hail-and-ride segment supports inclusive access**, particularly for older residents, parents with young children, and users with reduced mobility.
- Meeting or exceeding Sutton's standards for small-scale community developments.

Policy 34 – Environmental Protection –[including in relation to the applicant's arrangements for refuse storage]

- While not directly cited for amenity, this policy deals with pollution impacts, including noise and air quality.
- The absence of industrial or mechanical plant, commercial kitchens, or intensive night-time use means the proposal is well within acceptable thresholds.
- If required, a noise management statement can be submitted at full application to reinforce low impact.

Specifically in relation to refuse storage for the application site:

Refuse storage and recycling provision on-site is guided specifically **Policy 34 – Environmental Protection** and its associated **Technical Guidance Note: Sustainable Design and Construction (2018)**. These documents require that:

- All developments incorporate adequate and hygienic storage for waste and recycling,
- Refuse is stored in covered, secure, and accessible locations,
- Storage areas are located close to the public highway but designed to be discreet and non-detrimental to amenity or streetscape,
- Provision for both general waste and recyclable materials is required in line with borough-wide environmental targets.

Policy-Compliant Provision

The proposed development includes the following refuse strategy:

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- A **dedicated refuse and recycling storage area** is proposed within the rear yard, located discretely to the side of the building and screened from public view.
- **Separate bins** will be provided for general waste and recyclable materials, meeting Sutton's minimum standards for non-residential community uses.
- Access is designed to comply with **BS5906:2005 Waste Management in Buildings**, enabling ease of collection without disrupting users or neighbours.
- The refuse area is paved and weather-protected, ensuring hygiene and operational usability.
- Where appropriate, the use of clearly labelled bins and signage will encourage correct recycling behaviour from users and visitors.

The proposal therefore complies fully with **Sutton Local Plan Policy 34**, and the borough's **Design and Construction SPD**, by delivering a refuse strategy that is:

- Environmentally responsible,
- Functionally adequate for the proposed use,
- And sensitively integrated into the site layout to avoid visual or amenity impact.

Policy 35 – Transport Proposals

Objective: To promote sustainable travel and enhance Sutton's transport network.

Assessment:

- The site is located within 0.3 miles of Belmont Railway Station and is served by local bus routes. This ensures strong public transport accessibility, aligning with the policy's emphasis on using existing infrastructure efficiently.
- The S4 bus stop is on the corner of the site (on the junction of Holland Avenue and Dorset Road) and the S2 bus stop is less than 100 yards away on corner of York Road and Dorset Road. The majority of attendees will use these buses rather than the train station, as most are local.
- Both S2 and S4 bus routes in Sutton include hail and ride sections, especially on residential roads like Dorset Road, York Road, and Holland Avenue.
- The S4 bus operates a hail and ride service along Dorset Road and Holland Avenue, with a stop directly adjacent to the site. The S2 service, also operating hail and ride on nearby York Road, provides further access for local users. This flexible bus provision ensures highly walkable, demand-

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responsive transport options, especially beneficial for elderly and mobility-limited users.”

- The development does not compromise safeguarded transport routes or land needed for future infrastructure.
- No adverse impact is anticipated on borough-level schemes (e.g., the proposed tram extension or major highway upgrades).
- The proposal includes secure cycle parking, a key enabler of active travel in line with the borough’s Transport Strategy.
- As required by Policy 35, a Transport Statement or Plan can be provided at full application stage to demonstrate alignment with Sutton’s movement framework and multimodal access.

Policy 36 – Transport Impact

Purpose: Minimise negative transport impacts and manage parking.

Compliance Justification:

- The proposal includes **staggered prayer times**, particularly on Fridays, to avoid overlap with school runs and peak hours. This proactively addresses potential concerns about peak-time congestion.
- The site includes 12 parking bays plus 2 disabled, matching its use and catchment.
- Cycle storage for visitors and staff encourages modal shift.
- Located to bus stops less than 0.2 miles away and 0.3 miles from Belmont Station, supporting sustainable access.
- Traffic impact will be minimal due to dispersed usage throughout the day and non-peak scheduling.
A Transport Statement & Travel Plan forms part of our full planning submission.
- Most attendees are local, and capacity is full at other Mosques in Sutton. Many attendees to BASMA come walking from within the local area. For broader community services they currently attend other Mosques in Sutton, this increases car usage and further exacerbates parking problems at those centres.

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Policy 37 – Parking

Objective: Ensure adequate but not excessive parking, with support for sustainable modes.

Car Parking Provision:

- The proposed 14 spaces are proportionate to the proposed use, the local catchment, and aligns with the flexible standards for community facilities in outer borough areas with low PTAL (Public Transport Accessibility Level).
- Inclusion of 2 disabled bays supports inclusivity in line with Sutton's mobility and equalities goals.
- Parking is well-contained within the site and does not dominate the street frontage or visual setting.

Cycle Parking Provision:

- According to Sutton's **cycle parking standards** (which reflect the **London Plan's guidance** and Sutton's SPD):
 - **Places of worship/community facilities** should provide at least:
 - **1 space per 8 staff + 1 space per 100 visitors (long-stay)**
 - **1 space per 20 visitors (short stay)**
 - Provision shall include **Sheffield stands**, covered, in accessible locations near entrances.

Proposal Compliance:

- The scheme intends to provide a **dedicated secure cycle storage area**, with at least **8 cycle spaces**, in line with above guidance. A mix of long- and short-stay stands can be incorporated.

Electric Vehicle Charging:

- Provision for future **EV charging infrastructure** would align with best practice and may be conditioned.

Air Quality and Traffic Mitigation:

- As the area is not within an Air Quality Focus Area, there is **no specific mitigation** triggered, but the **minimisation of car use and modal shift measures** reinforce wider sustainability policies (31, 33, and 34).

Policy 38 – Infrastructure Delivery

Compliance Justification:

As a community facility, this development reduces pressure on public infrastructure by creating privately funded services.

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5.3 Biodiversity Enhancement Measures (in relation to Policy 26 & 33)

We have reviewed Sutton's Local Plan policies as noted here, in addition we have reviewed Suttons Policy Document:

Building A Sustainable Sutton: Technical Guidance Note for Developers
1 Carbon Offset Fund; 2 Biodiversity Accounting; 3 Green Space Factor
[April 2018]

According to the Sutton Local Plan (Policy 26 – Biodiversity):

- A biodiversity statement or survey is usually required when:
 - The site is within or near a designated habitat (e.g., Site of Importance for Nature Conservation).
 - The site supports protected species or significant green cover.
 - The development will result in significant vegetation loss or habitat disturbance.

Compliance Justification:

The site is a previously developed (brownfield) urban site, formerly used as an ambulance station.

- The proposed development involves the Change of Use of a previously developed [brownfield] site, formerly an ambulance station, together with a modest single-storey rear extension.
- There is no known ecological designation on or adjacent to the site.
- The development is minor in scale, and the extension is modest in footprint and mainly limited to the rear.

Implication:

Whilst the site does not warrant a full Biodiversity Statement or Phase 1 Habitat Survey, A detailed Preliminary Biodiversity Net Gain Statement, confirming the site's alignment with the Environment Act 2021 and Small Sites Metric (SSM) requirements, is provided in **Appendix B**.

In accordance with **Policy 26: Biodiversity** and **Policy 33: Climate Change Adaptation** of the **Sutton Local Plan (2018)**, the applicant recognises the importance of embedding biodiversity and climate resilience within the design of even small-scale community schemes.

As such, the proposal incorporates the following **site-level biodiversity and greening measures**, proportionate to the nature and scale of development:

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- **Pollinator-friendly planting** using low-maintenance, native species will be introduced at appropriate site boundaries, in line with Policy 26(b), to enhance local habitat value and contribute to Sutton's wider ecological network.
- **Planters and green screening** will be used to improve boundary treatment and soften built form, addressing Policy 33(b) by contributing to local climate adaptation and visual amenity.
- **Hanging plant baskets** along with **floor mounted planter boxes** will be incorporated into the proposal.
- One or more **bird nesting boxes** will be installed on a suitable non-public elevation to support small bird populations, providing small-scale habitat support under Policy 26(a).
- **Subject to Hydrology testing: Permeable paving** or porous hard surfacing will be used in select external areas, aligning with **Policy 32: Flood Risk and Sustainable Drainage**, to support sustainable water management and root development.

These measures are designed to ensure that the development contributes positively to the borough's environmental priorities, complies with adopted planning policy, and supports Sutton's ambitions under the **One Planet Strategy** for ecological and climate resilience.

Please also refer to the Preliminary Biodiversity Net Gain Statement in **Appendix B**

5.4 SPD guidance we have identified as relevant to the application site

Supplementary Planning Guidance and Technical Notes

In addition to the relevant policies of the Sutton Local Plan (2018) and the London Plan (2021), this application also takes into account material considerations contained in the Council's adopted Supplementary Planning Documents (SPDs) and associated technical guidance. While there is **no site-specific SPD** or area framework covering **Dorset Road or the Belmont Ward**, several borough-wide SPDs are directly relevant to the proposed development.

Urban Design Guide SPD (2008)

This SPD provides general guidance on site layout, built form, boundary treatment, and integration of new development into the surrounding context. The proposed development, comprising the Change of Use of a former ambulance station and a single-storey rear extension, reflects these principles through:

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- A sensitive design response that retains the existing building's position and street relationship.
- Use of sympathetic materials and massing to preserve visual harmony with nearby residential properties.
- Subdued and well-contained rear extension to avoid overdevelopment or adverse visual impact.
- Internal layout design reflects inclusive design principles by ensuring that **women and girls** have equitable and culturally appropriate access to worship and social facilities, consistent with the Urban Design Guide's expectations for dignity and accessibility in community infrastructure.
- The development will incorporate **Secured by Design Principles** as set out in the accompanying DAS, supporting the objectives of NPPF para. 97 and Sutton Local Plan Policy 28

Transport Assessments and Travel Plans SPD (2008)

A formal Transport Statement and Travel Plan is part of our full planning submission. BASMA has already engaged a Transport consultant for this purpose. The application shall be informed by their guidance, addressing amongst other matters:

- On-site car parking provision (12 bays plus 2 disabled spaces, 14 in total).
- Walking and cycling access, including new cycle storage.
- Programming measures such as **staggered Friday prayers** to manage peak hour movement.

This approach ensures consistency with sustainable transport and network impact minimisation expectations set out in both the Local Plan and this SPD.

Sustainable Design and Construction Guidance – Technical Guidance Note (2018)

This technical note supports Policies 31–34 of the Local Plan and outlines practical sustainability measures expected of minor developments. The applicant confirms that the proposal incorporates several key features:

- Enhanced insulation, LED lighting and energy-efficient systems during refurbishment.
- Exploration of low-carbon technologies, including solar PV or green roof options.
- Permeable paving and potential SuDS features.

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- Soft landscaping and biodiversity-friendly planting, as set out in line with urban greening expectations.

While the development does not meet the threshold for a full Energy or Sustainability Statement, the application follows the performance-based intent of the SPD.

Conclusion: The development aligns with the aims and recommendations of Sutton's relevant SPDs and demonstrates that borough-wide good practice has been applied to ensure high-quality, low-impact, and sustainable community infrastructure on a previously developed site in Belmont Ward.

6.0 London Wide Development Plan Policies:

6.1 The London Plan (Adopted March 2021)

The **London Plan 2021** is the **Spatial Development Strategy for Greater London**, prepared by the Mayor of London and adopted on 2 March 2021. It provides a strategic planning framework for all London boroughs and forms part of the statutory development plan for Sutton under the provisions of the Greater London Authority Act 1999.

The Plan sets out policies to shape the capital's growth through to 2041 and covers housing, economy, transport, design, the environment, and social infrastructure. It promotes Good Growth through six overarching objectives, including building inclusive communities, promoting sustainable transport, and tackling climate change.

Boroughs are required to ensure that local planning decisions are in general conformity with the London Plan. This application demonstrates compliance with a number of relevant policies including those relating to **social infrastructure (S1)**, **inclusive communities (GG1)**, **transport (T6)**, and **sustainable design (SI2)**

6.2. Assessment Against Relevant London Plan Policies

6.3 Policy GG1: Building Strong and Inclusive Communities

The proposal supports Policy GG1 by delivering inclusive and adaptable community infrastructure. It enables a locally based faith group to meet regularly in a dedicated facility, enhancing social integration, reducing isolation, and promoting participation. The site will also serve broader community needs beyond religious worship by hosting non-exclusive events and programmes for families, youth, elderly, and interfaith groups. The provision of accessible and welcoming space encourages cohesion and fulfils the London Plan's inclusivity aims.

6.4 Policy GG2: Making the Best Use of Land

The proposal makes efficient use of a well-located, previously developed site (brownfield land) in Outer London. The modest extension optimizes capacity without compromising surrounding amenity. It repurposes underused civic infrastructure for

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socially valuable use, in line with Policy GG2's directive to intensify and diversify land use, especially in areas with existing infrastructure.

6.5 Policy S1: Developing London's Social Infrastructure

The development contributes to the borough's social infrastructure by providing a permanent, flexible space for worship, education, community gatherings, and support services. As recognised in Policy S1, high-quality social infrastructure fosters cohesive neighbourhoods and supports growing and diverse communities. The location near St John's Community Hall—already serving the same end users—means the catchment is well established and service uptake will be immediate.

6.6 Policy D3: Optimizing Site Capacity through the Design-Led Approach

The site layout respects surrounding context, avoids overdevelopment, and supports inclusive access. The design-led approach ensures the rear extension maintains privacy, daylight, and avoids overshadowing. The car and cycle parking strategy supports Policy D3's aims to promote high-quality, functional, and sustainable design.

6.7 Policies T5 and T6: Cycling and Car Parking

The proposal includes secure cycle parking to encourage modal shift, and 10–12 car spaces on-site, including two disabled bays. This meets accessibility and sustainability expectations in Policies T5 and T6. Programming (e.g., staggered Friday prayers) reduces peak hour conflicts, particularly during school runs.

6.8 Conclusion from this section

The proposal complies with the overarching aims and strategic policies of the London Plan 2021. It represents an efficient and sensitive reuse of previously developed land, strengthens social infrastructure, and provides inclusive community benefits with limited impact on local amenities. The proposed development is a direct response to demonstrable need, informed by the community's current use of the nearby St John's Hall. The project supports Good Growth by enabling social inclusion, sustainable access, and effective land use.

7.0 National Development Plan Policies:

7.1 National Planning Policy Framework (NPPF, Revised July 2023)

The **National Planning Policy Framework (NPPF)** sets out the Government's planning policies for England and how these are expected to be applied. The current version was published in July 2023 and forms a material consideration in the determination of planning applications.

The NPPF promotes a **presumption in favour of sustainable development** and supports the creation of strong, vibrant, and healthy communities. It establishes the

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national policy framework within which Local Plans and Neighbourhood Plans are developed and encourages the **reuse of previously developed land**, provision of community infrastructure, and high standards of design and environmental stewardship.

This application aligns with key chapters of the NPPF, including those relating to **healthy communities (Chapter 8), promoting sustainable transport (Chapter 9), achieving well-designed places (Chapter 12), and making effective use of land (Chapter 11).**

7.2 Relevance of the National Planning Policy Framework (2024)

The NPPF 2024 sets out the Government's planning policies for England and is a material consideration in planning decisions. The Framework promotes sustainable development across three key objectives—economic, social, and environmental—and places emphasis on reusing brownfield land, enhancing community infrastructure, and ensuring well-designed, inclusive development. This proposal supports the NPPF's strategic aims, particularly those in Chapters 2, 8, 9, 11, and 12.

7.3 Assessment Against Key NPPF Policies

7.4 Chapter 2: Achieving Sustainable Development (para. 8–11)

The proposed development supports all three objectives of sustainable development. It provides community infrastructure (social), encourages brownfield reuse and low-impact construction (environmental), and facilitates a local support network for residents and businesses (economic). The scheme exemplifies the NPPF's presumption in favour of sustainable development.

7.5 Chapter 8: Promoting Healthy and Safe Communities (para. 96–102)

The development accords with Paragraphs 98(a)–(e) by delivering a dedicated, accessible space for religious and community use. The proposal guards against the loss of local facilities and enhances the social, cultural, and wellbeing infrastructure of the Belmont area. The programming includes services for youth, elderly, interfaith dialogue, and general hire—contributing to inclusion and cohesion.

7.6 Chapter 11: Making Effective Use of Land (para. 119–125)

The site is previously developed and lies in a sustainable, well-connected location. The scheme is efficient in its layout and land use, representing good practice in reusing existing infrastructure while maintaining a low building footprint. The modest extension is proportionate and necessary to accommodate multifunctional community use.

7.7 Chapter 9: Promoting Sustainable Transport (para. 109–118)

The proposal provides on-site parking and secure cycle facilities, with good access to Belmont Station. Travel to the site is manageable on foot for many end users, especially given existing use at nearby St John's Hall.

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The availability of hail-and-ride services to and from the site between regulated bus stops supports flexible, car-free access options and reinforces the scheme's low transport impact profile.

The proposal has sustainable transport credentials and tangible benefits. The **hail-and-ride service** is a valuable feature that directly enhances **walkability and sustainable access**, particularly for:

- Elderly users
- Women with children
- Those unable to walk the full distance
- Local residents in low-car households

Programming events such as staggered Friday prayers—ensures minimal traffic conflict during sensitive times such as the school run. This approach reflects the principles in Paragraphs 110 and 117 of the NPPF.

7.8 Chapter 12: Achieving Well-Designed Places (para. 129–139)

The scheme has been carefully designed to respect the surrounding context, with high-quality materials and a sensitively located extension. Privacy and daylight for neighbours are preserved, while the development provides a visually cohesive and accessible layout. The approach aligns with Paragraph 135 in promoting inclusive, safe, and well-integrated community development.

7.9 Conclusion from this section

The proposed Change of Use and modest extension at the former Belmont Ambulance Station fully aligns with the National Planning Policy Framework 2024. It contributes positively to sustainable development, makes effective use of land, and meets a clearly identified community need with minimal adverse impact. The proposal should be supported in accordance with the presumption in favour of sustainable development.

8.0 Conclusion and Planning Balance

The proposed redevelopment of the former Dorset Road Ambulance Station into a multi-functional Place of Worship and Community Centre represents a clear and compelling example of plan-led, community-driven development. It directly addresses a well-evidenced shortfall in faith-based and inclusive community infrastructure in the Belmont area, delivering public benefit through the reuse of previously developed land in a sustainable and respectful manner.

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As demonstrated throughout this Statement, the proposal aligns with the overarching aims and specific policies of the **Sutton Local Plan (2018)**, **The London Plan (2021)**, and the **National Planning Policy Framework (2023/2024)**, including:

- Promoting **social infrastructure** that is accessible, inclusive, and responsive to local demographic change (Policies 22, S1, NPPF Ch. 8).
- Making **efficient use of brownfield land** within the urban area (Policies 1, GG2, NPPF Ch. 11).
- Safeguarding **residential amenity and local character** through design-led, low-impact development (Policies 28–29, D3, NPPF Ch. 12).
- Supporting **active travel, low-carbon access**, and sustainable transport strategies (Policies 35–37, T5–T6, NPPF Ch. 9).
- Integrating **biodiversity and climate adaptation** at site level, in accordance with borough-wide environmental goals (Policies 26, 31, 33, SI2).

The facility will provide a **permanent base and re-purposed community asset** for the Belmont and Sutton Muslim Assembly (BASMA), enabling delivery of:

- Daily and Friday congregational prayers.
- Educational, interfaith, and health-based programmes.
- Support for youth, elderly, and families within a welcoming, inclusive setting.

Compared to the site's former operational use as an ambulance depot, the proposed development:

- Reduces traffic intensity and operational hours.
- Offers managed, scheduled activities with minimal disturbance.
- Improves site appearance, function, and security for neighbouring residents.

By removing the constraints of temporary hall hire and creating a **dedicated community space**, the scheme strengthens **social cohesion, neighbourhood resilience**, and **equity of access** — all core planning objectives at both local and national level.

The accompanying consultant reports — including transport (Caneparo Associates), flood risk and drainage (Unda Consulting), BNG, energy and water efficiency (Syntegra Consulting), and acoustic management (Hann Tucker Associates) — collectively confirm that the development performs to the standards expected for sustainable community infrastructure in Sutton.

For detailed compliance evidence, refer to the supporting technical reports accompanying this Full Planning submission.

8.1. Planning Balance

In applying the planning balance and having regard to Section 38(6) of the Planning and Compulsory Purchase Act 2004, the proposal delivers **clear and measurable public benefits** that:

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- Outweigh any minor and manageable impacts.
- Address a longstanding gap in infrastructure provision.
- Enhance local identity, participation, and wellbeing.

8.2. Final Statement

This is a modest, well-managed proposal that transforms an underused public asset into a vital piece of social infrastructure. It promotes inclusive growth, contributes to a resilient and cohesive Belmont community, and exemplifies sustainable, locally rooted development in line with the borough's planning vision.

We respectfully request the application should therefore be supported as a positive, proportionate, and policy-compliant response to local infrastructure need.

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Appendix A – Belmont Ward Demographic Summary and Community Context

1.0 Introduction

This appendix provides a summary of relevant demographic and community context data for **Belmont Ward**, as extracted from published sources and referenced in the accompanying **Design and Access Statement**. The purpose of this appendix is to demonstrate the socio-cultural and population-based need for a dedicated, multi-functional community and worship facility at Dorset Road, aligned with the proposed use.

The data below evidences key characteristics of the local population that justify a **faith-based, culturally inclusive and accessible community centre**, with particular focus on **Muslim population trends, cultural diversity, and growing family and educational need** in the Belmont area.

This evidence supports the application's alignment with:

- **Sutton Local Plan Policy 22 – Social and Community Infrastructure**
- **Policy 43 – Equality and Inclusion**
- **London Plan Policy S1 – Developing London's Social Infrastructure**
- **NPPF Chapter 8 – Promoting Healthy and Inclusive Communities**
-

2.0 Demographic Profile of Belmont Ward

From publicly available data on **Sutton Council's data dashboard**, Belmont Ward demonstrates the following demographic characteristics:

Ethnic minorities:

Country of birth: The proportion of people from the Middle East and Asia within the ward is higher than the Sutton average [14% compared to the Sutton average of 11.5%]

Country of birth

	Belmont (Sutton) Ward (as of 2022)		Sutton Local Authority		England Country	
	count	%	count	%	count	%
All usual residents	11,864	100.0	209,639	100.0	56,490,048	100.0
Europe	9,405	79.3	171,813	82.0	50,730,043	89.8
Europe: United Kingdom	8,216	69.3	151,447	72.2	46,687,506	82.6
Europe: Ireland	105	0.9	1,925	0.9	314,674	0.6
Europe: Other	1,084	9.1	18,441	8.8	3,727,863	6.6
Africa	543	4.6	9,221	4.4	1,558,199	2.8
Middle East and Asia	1,656	14.0	24,124	11.5	3,241,701	5.7
The Americas and the Caribbean	228	1.9	3,810	1.8	789,999	1.4
Antarctica and Oceania (including Australasia) and Other	32	0.3	671	0.3	170,106	0.3

[Show table notes...](#)

Source: ONS - 2021 Census (TS004A)

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Ethnic group: the proportion of Asian, Asian British or Asian Welsh within the ward is higher than the Sutton average [22.4% compared to the Sutton average of 17.5%]

Ethnic group

	Belmont (Sutton)		Sutton		Persons	
	Ward (as of 2022)		Local Authority		England	
	count	%	count	%	count	%
All usual residents	11,863	100.0	209,636	100.0	56,490,048	100.0
Asian, Asian British or Asian Welsh	2,652	22.4	36,787	17.5	5,426,392	9.6
Black, Black British, Black Welsh, Caribbean or African	571	4.8	12,465	5.9	2,381,724	4.2
Mixed or Multiple ethnic groups	555	4.7	10,162	4.8	1,669,378	3.0
White	7,713	65.0	143,145	68.3	45,783,401	81.0
Other ethnic group	372	3.1	7,077	3.4	1,229,153	2.2

In order to protect against disclosure of personal information, records have been swapped between different geographic areas and counts perturbed by small amounts. Small counts at the lowest geographies will be most affected.

Source: ONS - 2021 Census (TS021)

Ethnic groups in Sutton:

As noted: in 2021, 17.5% of Sutton residents identified their ethnic group within the "Asian, Asian British or Asian Welsh" category, this is up from 11.6% in 2011. The 6.0 percentage-point change was the largest increase among high-level ethnic groups in this area.

[extracted from ONS – Census Area Changes]

For the Belmont ward the percentage point increase is 10.8%

Religion: the proportion of Muslims within the ward is higher than the Sutton average [9.4% compared to the Sutton average of 7.0 %]

Religion

	Belmont (Sutton)		Sutton		Persons	
	Ward (as of 2022)		Local Authority		England	
	count	%	count	%	count	%
All usual residents	11,863	100.0	209,640	100.0	56,490,048	100.0
No religion	3,610	30.4	67,769	32.3	20,715,664	36.7
Christian	5,060	42.7	95,960	45.8	26,167,899	46.3
Buddhist	62	0.5	1,822	0.9	262,433	0.5
Hindu	1,097	9.2	14,666	7.0	1,020,533	1.8
Jewish	39	0.3	407	0.2	269,283	0.5
Muslim	1,119	9.4	14,736	7.0	3,801,186	6.7
Sikh	39	0.3	447	0.2	520,092	0.9
Other religion	108	0.9	1,244	0.6	332,410	0.6
Not answered	729	6.1	12,589	6.0	3,400,548	6.0

In order to protect against disclosure of personal information, records have been swapped between different geographic areas and counts perturbed by small amounts. Small counts at the lowest geographies will be most affected.

Source: ONS - 2021 Census (TS030)

A comparison with the 2011 census data shows that the Muslim population within the borough has increased from 4.1% to 7.0% with a similar increase in the Hindu population

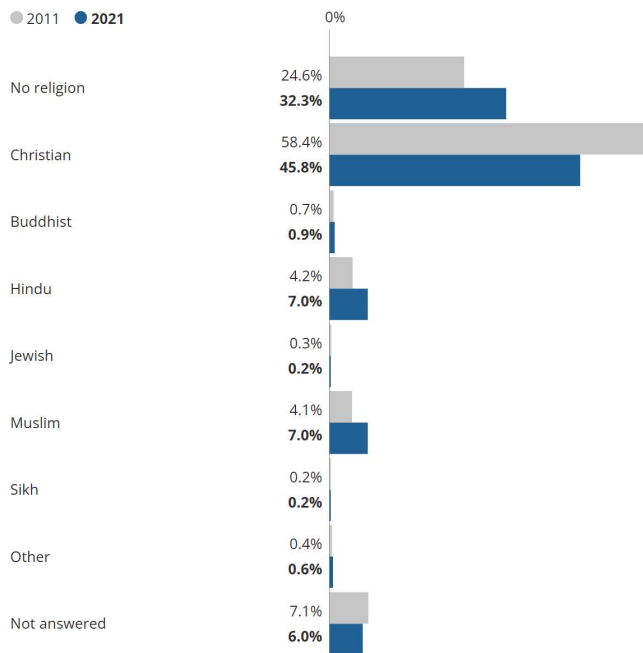
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In 2021, 32.3% of usual residents in Sutton reported having "No religion"

Percentage of usual residents by religion, Sutton

2011 2021



Source: Office for National Statistics – 2011 Census and Census 2021

Residential provision in communal housing development:

The proportion of people living in communal housing is significantly higher within the ward than the Sutton average [1.6% compared to the Sutton average of 0.6%]

Usual resident population

	Belmont (Sutton) Ward (as of 2022)		Sutton Local Authority		Persons England Country	
	count	%	count	%	count	%
All usual residents	11,864	100.0	209,639	100.0	56,490,048	100.0
Lives in a household	11,677	98.4	208,425	99.4	55,504,302	98.3
Lives in a communal establishment	187	1.6	1,214	0.6	985,746	1.7

In order to protect against disclosure of personal information, records have been swapped between different geographic areas and counts perturbed by small amounts. Small counts at the lowest geographies will be most affected.

Source: ONS - 2021 Census (TS001)

[Show table notes...](#)

Family and Age Characteristics

- Belmont has a growing number of **multi-generational households**, with a corresponding need for family-oriented, intergenerational space
- High percentage of **school-aged children** and youth who require access to safe, structured educational and mentoring environments

3.0 Summary Statement

The demographic profile of Belmont Ward provides a clear evidence base in support of the proposed development. The data demonstrates:

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- A significant Muslim population with unmet worship and community needs
- High ethnic and cultural diversity not currently matched by local infrastructure
- Pressures on existing mosques, resulting in long travel distances and social exclusion
- Strong justification for faith-sensitive, family-supportive, inclusive design
- Alignment with Sutton's and London's strategic planning objectives for equity, cohesion, and sustainable social infrastructure

This information provides a robust basis for concluding that the proposed development at Dorset Road meets a **documented local need**, supports **inclusive growth**, and addresses a clear **infrastructure shortfall** in Belmont.

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APPENDIX B – Response to London Borough of Sutton's Pre-Application Feedback [Ref: PRE 2025/00079]

LBS Pre-Application Report

Application No: PRE2025/00079
Report Date: 28th August 2025



To: Umair Waheed

Applicant: Hassan Shirwani

Unit 3
679-691 High Road Leyton
Leyton
E10 6RA

4C Upper Mulgrave Road
Cheam
SM2 7AZ

Dear Umair Waheed

Thank you for submitting your pre-application to the London Borough of Sutton validated on 10th June 2025. This letter provides the Councils formal response to your proposal following the meeting held on 8th August 2025.

Address: Ambulance Station Dorset Road Belmont SM2 6JH

Ward: Belmont

Proposal: Change of use from Use Class Sui Generis (ambulance station) to Mixed Use Classes F.1 (place of worship) and F.2 (community hub) including the erection of a single storey side and rear extension and provision of a partial first floor.

Case Officer: Polly Davidson

Relevant Site History

Planning Application Reference: 80/21274— Address: Belmont Hospital Land, Brighton Road— Proposal: Residential development at 70 h.r.p.a. with new access road and provision for community centre, school playing field, primary school & public open space— Status: GTD— Decision: GTD— Date Decision Issued: 18-NOV-80—

Planning Application Reference: 8527700A— Address: Sutton Bowling Club Dorset Road Sutton SM2 6JA— Proposal: Display of non-illuminated directional sign 96-4-53— Status: GTD— Decision: GTD— Date Decision Issued: 30-APR-85—

Planning Application Reference: 68/4456— Address: Ambulance Station Dorset Road Belmont SM2— Proposal: Erection of ambulance station 42-3-30— Status: GTD— Decision: GTD— Date Decision Issued: 11-DEC-68—

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Planning Application Reference: 77/17209— Address: Belmont Hospital, Brighton Road, Sutton— Proposal: Use of approximately 48 acres for residential purposes, community facilities, primary school, public open space and a school playing field with access from Dorset Road and Hulverstone Close— Status: WDN— Decision: WDN— Date Decision Issued: —

Site Specific Designations

Article 4s	Article 4 Direction - Boroughwide HMO Restriction
Smoke Control Orders	Smoke Control Zone
TPO Polygons Uniform Database	Ref: 145 - Status: CONF
TPO Polygons Uniform Database	Ref: 145 - Status: CONF
TPO Polygons Uniform Database	Ref: 145 - Status: CONF

MATERIAL PLANNING POLICIES

Section 38(6) of the Planning and Compulsory Purchase Act 2004 states that when determining a planning application, regard is to be had to the development plan, and the determination shall be made in accordance with the development plan, unless material considerations indicate otherwise. The development plan for the London Borough of Sutton comprises the following documents:

- The London Plan 2021
- The Sutton Local Plan 2018

Also a material consideration in determining planning applications are:

- National Planning Policy Framework 2024 (NPPF)
- National Planning Practice Guidance (NPPG)
- Adopted London Borough of Sutton Supplementary Planning Documents
- Human Rights Act 1998
- Equality Act 2010

London Plan 2021 Policies :

GG1 Building strong and inclusive communities
GG2 Making the best use of land
D1 London's form, character and capacity for growth
D3 Optimising site capacity through design-led approach
D4 Delivery good design
D5 Inclusive design

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D12 Fire Safety
D14 Noise
S1 Developing London's social infrastructure
G6 Biodiversity and access to nature
G7 Trees and Woodlands
SI 2 Minimising greenhouse gas emissions
SI 4 Managing heat risk
SI 5 Water infrastructure
SI 8 Waste capacity and net waste self-sufficiency
SI 12 Flood risk management
SI 13 Sustainable drainage
T3 Transport capacity, connectivity and safeguarding
T4 Assessing and mitigating transport impact
T5 Cycling
T6 Car parking
T6.5 Non-residential disabled persons parking
T7 Deliveries, servicing and construction

Sutton Local Plan 2018 Policies :

1 Sustainable Growth
22 Social and community infrastructure, including public houses
26 Biodiversity
28 Character and Design
29 Protecting Amenity
31 Carbon and Energy
32 Flood Risk and Sustainable Drainage
33 Climate Change Adoptions
34 Environmental Protection
36 Transport Impact
37 Parking

Supplementary Planning Documents :

SPD 14 Creating Locally Distinctive Places 'Urban Design'

Principle

Principle:

The NPPF requires the Council to promote an effective use of land in meeting the need for homes and other uses, while safeguarding and improving the environment and ensuring safe and healthy living conditions. It states that strategic policies should set out a clear strategy for accommodating objectively assessed needs, in a way that makes as much use as possible of previously-developed or 'brownfield' land. It goes further in stating that decisions should encourage multiple benefits from urban land, including through mixed use schemes and taking opportunities to achieve net environmental gains.

The London Plan 2021 encourages intensification and optimising of land subject to justification within the local context.

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Policy S1 of the London Plan states that social infrastructure plays an important role in developing strong and inclusive communities. It can provide opportunities to bring different groups of people together, contributing to social integration and the desirability of a place.

Policy HC5 of the London Plan aims to protect existing cultural venues, facilities and uses where appropriate and support the development of new cultural venues in town centres and places with good public transport connectivity.

This application seeks pre-application advice for the change of use of the former Sutton Ambulance Station, Dorset Road, Belmont (Use Class Sui Generis), into a mixed-use Community Hub and Place of Worship (Use Classes F.1 and F.2), to be delivered by the Belmont and Sutton Muslim Assembly (BASMA).

The proposed development will, according to the applicants:

- Provide a permanent base for spiritual, social, educational, and interfaith activities
- Introduce dedicated facilities for women, elderly users, and families currently underserved by existing provision
- Reduce pressure on over-capacity religious centres elsewhere in the borough.
- Promote active travel, inclusive access, and modal shift via well-connected walking routes and hail-and-ride bus services.
- Deliver biodiversity uplift and urban greening measures in line with BNG obligations and Policies 26 & 33 of the Sutton Local Plan.

Policy 22 of the Sutton Local Plan states that the council will grant planning permission for the development of social and community infrastructure (as defined in the glossary, including places of worship and community / cultural facilities such as proposed) where it:

- (i) is accessible by a range of transport modes, in particular by walking, cycling and public transport.
- (ii) provides flexible and adaptable space, where practicable.
- (iii) is close to or accessible to the community it is intended to serve and is of a suitable scale to meet that need.
- (iv) is designed and sited to enable the shared use of premises and playing fields for community purposes.
- (v) would not have any adverse environmental effects.
- (vi) in the case of proposals for large developments generating significant numbers of trips, such as indoor sports facilities, are located within or on the edge of town centres or other areas of higher public transport accessibility.

The site has a low PTAL rating of 1a which means there is extremely poor access to this location by public transport. This is a concern expressed in the relevant section below.

It is evident that the proposed use of the site broadly complies with the aims set out within Policies S1 and HC5 of the London Plan, and taking into consideration Policy 22 of the Sutton Local Plan, it is considered that, from the supporting information provided, the proposal provides flexible and adaptable space, where practicable, is close to or accessible to the community it is intended to serve and is of a suitable scale to meet that need. It is designed and sited to enable the shared use of premises for community purposes, all of which is welcomed by Sutton Council.

Whilst the principle of the change of use of this redundant ambulance station is supported, the success of any future planning application will also depend on compliance with all other relevant national and local planning policies.

Design & Townscape

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Design and Townscape:

The London Plan encourages intensification of sites subject to exceptional design and architectural quality, relationship to its local context and attention to the public realm. In particular, Policy 28 of the Sutton Local Plan and SPD14 'Urban Design Guide' along with National policy requires development to respect or reinforce the character and identity of the area and avoid developments which do not integrate well into the surroundings.

o The proposal involves the extension and refurbishment of the existing building with a single storey extension to the north and the western side of the building. The proposal also includes the increase in height of the building to create a central prayer hall. It is noted that any windows in this upper part of the building should be obscure glazed to ensure that there is no perceived overlooking to neighbours. It is noted that the intention is to create a central men's prayer hall that has height rather than adding an additional floor. It is likely to be a condition of any future application that no internal mezzanine floors can be added to the building.

o Internally, the building will comprise a flexible prayer and community use space, separated by folding partitions, toilet and wash room facilities, kitchens and office space.

o Modest external works at the site will also include resurfacing, a new parking layout, enhanced boundary treatments, and provision of cycle storage and refuse facilities.

o The submitted Design and Access statement sets out a couple of options for the external treatment of the extended building. You are advised that Option A appears to be the most successful as it is considered that the dark timber and red brickwork would compliment the surrounding development. The vertical window pattern and brick detailing would appear to create a visually attractive building, improving on the existing situation.

o Externally, you are advised to incorporate soft landscaping features where possible and any new hard standing should be porous to reduce surface water flooding.

The proposed building is considered to be an acceptable design, external materials could be conditioned on any future planning application.

Impact on Neighbours

Impact on Neighbours:

In accordance with policy 29 of the Sutton Local Plan, the council will not grant planning permission for any development that adversely affects the privacy, outlook or daylight and sunlight of adjoining occupiers, or would create unacceptable noise and vibration levels and the council will take into consideration times when such disturbances are likely to occur.

o Given the location of this site, there are a number of residential properties surrounding the site. The surrounding area is predominantly residential.

o To the east of the site is a flatted development known as Buckingham Court, this development is in close proximity to the application site. It is noted that there are windows within the flank elevation facing the application site, however the section of the building to be increased in height should be a sufficient distance from these windows to prevent an unacceptable impact on outlook or daylight.

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o The main properties to take into consideration to the west of the site are nos. 69 and 71 Holland Avenue. These two properties have private rear gardens adjoining the application site. Directly opposite the site are 66 Avenue Road and 49 Balmoral Way, both of which also need to be considered due to their proximity to the site.

o Whilst it is considered that the proposed change of use and extensions at the site are unlikely to result in a significant impact on the outlook, privacy or daylight currently enjoyed by the occupants of the surrounding properties. The Council does have concerns at this stage that the proposed change of use could result in raised noise and disturbance which could be significant within this residential setting. This is due to the coming and going of vehicles, which would be parked close to the rear gardens of the Holland Road properties, and from members of the community attending and leaving the site late in the evenings during busy events such as Friday prayer sessions.

o An example of the events likely to take place at the community centre has been provided and whilst the majority of these planned activities will attract an acceptable amount of people and will be held at times of the day where disturbance to neighbours would be minimal, the Council are also aware that the busiest events will be Friday prayer sessions, which could attract up to 120 people and the centre would be open until 11pm. As it is not reasonable or practical to restrict the number of people attending Friday prayer, the Council will be looking at the worse case scenario, whereby the maximum capacity of the building could be reached, which is understood to be 250, and the latest time that events could take place which is currently proposed to be 11pm. At present the Council do have concerns about the noise and disturbance that would be caused in this residential area by 250 people leaving the site at 11pm. Please be aware that whilst the worse case scenario might not happen, at planning committee, officers are likely to be asked what the maximum number of people attending the building would be and what are the earliest and latest times of operation.

o A site visit would also be carried out to identify any impacts on neighbour amenity that are not evident at this stage.

Any future application will be assessed against Policy 29 of the Sutton Local Plan 2018.

Traffic & Parking

Traffic and Parking:

In accordance with Policies 35 and 36 of the Sutton Local Plan 2018, development proposals will be required to make appropriate provisions for sustainable transport modes and will be assessed for their impact on the existing and proposed transport infrastructure and services, and the local environment. Additionally, Policy 37 of the Sutton Local Plan 2018 requires development proposals to provide the appropriate amount of car parking and secure cycle storage in accordance with the council's restraint-based maximum car and cycle parking standards and to ensure the safe and efficient operation of the transport network.

The site has a PTAL rating of 1a, indicating a very poor level of public transport accessibility. However it is noted that Belmont Station is a short walk away from the site and a hail and ride bus operates from Holland Avenue.

The submitted plans indicate that off street parking would be provided on site for 10 vehicles, in addition to this there would be two electric vehicle charging spaces and two disabled badge holder spaces.

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Cycle parking is also shown on the plan, however the applicant is advised that the proposed location could be unsuitable as it could conflict with the disabled parking space, making it difficult for people to get bikes safely in and out of the cycle store. The cycle store should be covered and secure and full details should be submitted at application stage. Facilities such as showers and lockers should be provided to encourage cycle trips for both men and women.

The proposal by the applicant to conduct a parking survey to the Lambeth Methodology is welcomed. The undertaking to include the busiest time on a Friday is important, as the travel survey indicates that there will be a demand for approximately 21 on-street parking spaces at this time (assuming that all of the off-street parking spaces are occupied).

The plans provided indicate that the existing gated vehicular access will be retained. It would be beneficial in both safety and active travel terms if a dedicated pedestrian access could be provided to allow pedestrians to enter and exit the facilities away from manoeuvring vehicles.

The existing Dorset Road access 'Keep Clear' carriageway markings and accompanying sign in the footway will be made redundant by the proposals and should be removed at the applicant's expense.

Given that one of the big concerns that will be expressed by local residents will be the possible impact on on-street parking demand and highway safety at times when the centre is at its busiest (Friday prayer sessions), you are advised to provide robust evidence and surveys that demonstrate that the proposed use would not result in an unacceptable impact to the surrounding area in terms of parking pressure and highway safety implications. It should also be noted that there is a proposed strategic development at the London Cancer Hub and concerns have been raised by local residents in regards to parking in this area from that development as well.

In summary, there are no fundamental highways objections to the proposals at this stage; with a development of this scope and scale there is however the requirement for the applicant to progress standard supporting transport documents (to accompany any planning application); these include, but are not necessarily limited to: a Transport Assessment, Servicing and Delivery Plan, Construction Logistics Plan, Travel Plan.

Other

Sustainability - Drainage:

Paragraph 163 of the NPPF seeks that when determining any planning application, local planning authorities should ensure that flood risk is not increased elsewhere. Where appropriate, applications should be supported by a site specific flood risk assessment.

Policy SI 12 of the London Plan states that development proposals must comply with the flood risk assessment and management requirements set out in the NPPF and the associated technical guidance on flood risk over the lifetime of the development. Policy SI 13 of the London Plan states that new development should utilise sustainable urban drainage systems (SuDs) unless there are practical reasons for not doing so, and should aim to achieve greenfield run-off rates and ensure that surface water run-off is managed as close to its source as possible.

Furthermore Policy 32 of the Sutton Local Plan states that proposed developments should avoid or minimise all sources of flood risk to people and property, taking account of climate change, without increasing flood risk elsewhere. Policy 32 also states that development proposals should incorporate effective sustainable drainage (SuDS) measures as part of their design and layout in order to manage surface water run-off as close to its source as possible and to achieve the

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minimum SuDS performance standards that are relevant to the development through application of the Mayor's drainage hierarchy.

Any future application should be accompanied by relevant surface water run-off calculations to demonstrate that peak run-off rates and volumes for the 1 in 100 year event achieve greenfield run-off rates for the same event, unless it can be demonstrated that all opportunities to minimise final site run-off, as close as reasonably practicable to greenfield runoff rates, have been taken in line with the Mayor's drainage hierarchy. In such cases, run-off rates must not exceed 3 times the calculated greenfield rate in accordance with the Mayor's Sustainable Design and Construction SPG. It should also be ensured that the site drainage strategy can contain the 1 in 30 year event (+ climate change) without flooding and that any flooding occurring between the 1 in 30 and 1 in 100 year event (+ climate change) will be safely contained on site.

Any formal planning application would be subject to consultation from the Council's Sustainability Officer and it should be noted that relevant SUD's / flooding details and water usage calculations would need to be submitted at application stage and will not be dealt with by condition.

Sustainability- Energy:

London Plan Policies SI 1 Improving air quality and SI 2 Minimising greenhouse gas emissions, have a general expectation that an Energy Statement is submitted for developments of varying scale. All planning applications for new dwellings or major non-residential developments should be supported by an Energy Statement incorporating 'as-designed' Building Regulations Part L outputs to demonstrate how the relevant targets for reducing CO2 emissions will be met. An Energy Statement demonstrating how these targets are to be met should be submitted with any application. The statement must incorporate 'as-designed' Building Regulations Part L outputs to demonstrate how the target for reducing CO2 emissions will be met. The Energy Statement should include calculations of energy demand and emissions at each stage of the Mayor's energy hierarchy for both regulated and non-regulated elements in line with GLA 'Guidance on Preparing Energy Assessments' as amended. Any shortfall in regulated CO2 emissions will need to be offset by a financial contribution which would be secured by legal agreement.

Policy 33 seeks to ensure new developments should achieve water efficiency measures and states that proposals should ensure that water use can be limited to 110 litres per person per day, evidence of this should be submitted with any future application.

There is therefore a need for an Energy Statement to be submitted as part of any subsequent planning application to show how the proposal would achieve a reduction in regulated CO2 emissions.

Sutton has declared a Climate Emergency and so it is imperative that officers are confident that in the absence of adequate details, the strategy to deal with climate change policies is set out in order to ensure that any condition placed on a development is capable of being complied with. It is not considered acceptable to leave matters for later approval by condition when the Council has no clear understanding of how you intend to meet the requirements of policy and be able to comply with the relevant conditions. The Sustainability Officer needs to be shown that the proposal will be sustainable at the decision making stage.

Trees and Landscaping:

In accordance with Policy 28 of the Sutton Local Plan 2018, new developments will be expected to respect and retain existing landforms and natural features of application sites, including trees of

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amenity value, hedges and other landscape features, and make suitable provision for high quality additional landscaping.

Photos and images of the site appear to show that there are significant mature trees and planting within the site which could be of high amenity value. These trees appear to be located to the western and northern edge of the site, at application stage, if any of the existing soft landscape strip along the western boundary of the site is to be reduced to accommodate the proposed parking on site, full details of this should be submitted together with details of the root protection areas of the existing trees at the site.

Any future proposal should not result in the loss or harm of any trees or landscaping features that currently contribute to the amenity of the surrounding area, root protection areas should be carefully considered. A full arboricultural survey and report should be submitted with any future application.

Biodiversity:

The application appears to result in the loss of some soft landscaping at the site as part of the proposal, a Report of Biodiversity Net Gain Calculation, Preliminary Ecological Appraisal and Preliminary Roost Assessment together with drawings showing indicative locations of bird boxes and other wildlife features should be submitted with any future application.

Biodiversity Net Gain is mandatory under Schedule 7A of the Town and Country Planning Act 1990 (as inserted by Schedule 14 of the Environment Act 2021). Developers must deliver a BNG of 10%. This means a development will result in more or better quality natural habitat than there was before development. More information can be found using the following link:

<https://www.gov.uk/guidance/understanding-biodiversity-net-gain>

A condition would be required to secure the wildlife features on site and a condition requiring a statement of conformity to enhance the biodiversity value of the land in accordance with Policy 26 of the Sutton Local Plan 2018.

Fire Safety Statement :

Following the publication of the London Plan in March 2021 all applications are required to meet the highest standards of fire safety. As part of any future application, fire safety information will have to be submitted to accord with policy D12a of the London Plan.

Making an Application

The [Planning Portal](#) explains how to apply for planning permission.

To enable us to consider your proposal, you must submit the correct application form, fee and include the necessary drawings and supporting information as contained within the [LBS Local Validation List](#).

Building Regulations

Please note that you may also require approval under the Building Regulations. If you are in any doubt about this you can get further information via <http://www.sutton.gov.uk/buildingcontrol> or by emailing buildingcontrol@sutton.gov.uk.

Community Infrastructure Levy (CIL)

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Please note that new developments often attract a CIL charge, this is usually on extensions over 100sqm in floor area or any development which creates new units but can also fall upon conversions. Further reading can be found here;

Sutton CIL – www.sutton.gov.uk/cil

Mayor CIL - <https://www.gov.uk/guidance/community-infrastructure-levy>

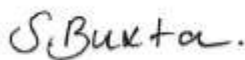
Questions in relation to CIL should be sent to planningobligations@sutton.gov.uk

Conclusion

It is concluded that this pre-application submission for the Change of Use of the former Sutton Ambulance Station (Sui Generis), Dorset Road, into a mixed-use Community Hub and Place of Worship (Use Classes F.1 and F.2), is likely to be acceptable in principle, however at this pre-application stage, as detailed above, the Council do have concerns regarding the noise and disturbance that could be caused to the surrounding residents and the impact that the proposal could have on the parking situation within the surrounding streets during the busiest events at the centre.

Whilst it is proposed that many of the community sessions that would take place at the centre would have a limited amount of people attending, it is evident that the proposed building could have a high maximum capacity, and is likely to attract a significant number of people from the surrounding community for certain events, whilst it would not be reasonable or effective to restrict the number of people that could attend, the hours of use could be limited to ensure that levels of disturbance to neighbours could be minimised, this is an issue you will need to consider prior to making an application.

As mentioned during our meeting, you are strongly advised prior to the submission of any application, to engage with local residents and groups within the local area as this will help provide reassurance to those residents that might need more information regarding the proposed community use and provide BASMA with links that will assist in achieving the multi use of the community centre and establish good strong relationships.



Sarah Buxton
Area Planning Manager

We provide these views and opinions in good faith and without prejudice to formal consideration of any planning application, which will be subject to formal consultation and ultimately decided by the Council. We cannot guarantee that any application made would be valid or would be approved. If there is a material change in circumstance or new information comes to light then less weight might be given to this document.

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A. Design & Townscape

Council Feedback Summary

The London Borough of Sutton's pre-application response (Ref: PRE2025/00079) confirmed that the proposed architectural approach was visually appropriate and well-considered. The Council specifically endorsed *Option A* of the submitted design concepts, noting that *"the dark timber and red brickwork would complement the surrounding development and the vertical window pattern and brick detailing would create a visually attractive building, improving on the existing situation."*

The Council therefore raised no objection to the form, height, or materiality of the scheme.

However, two design matters were identified for further clarification at full application stage:

1. Confirmation that **soft landscaping and permeable surface treatments** would be incorporated to assist surface water management; and
2. Assurance that **any upper-level windows introduced through the central hall roof design** would be **obscure glazed** to prevent overlooking of nearby residential properties.

BASMA Consultant Team Response

1. Landscape and Surface Treatment Enhancement

In direct response to the Council's request for increased soft landscaping and sustainable surface treatment, the **final Landscape Layout (Drawing No. AC.2025.861 Rev A)** and **UNDA Drainage Review (Nov 2025)** confirm that:

- The majority of the external hardstanding areas — including the front forecourt and side access paths — are now designed as **permeable paving** systems consistent with *Sutton Local Plan Policy 32 (Flood Risk and Sustainable Drainage)*.
- **New planting beds and soft landscaped borders** have been introduced along the site's southern and western boundaries, using mixed native species (Privet, Holly, and mixed ornamental hedging).
- A **rain garden feature** has been integrated at the front edge of the car park, providing natural attenuation of surface runoff and contributing to biodiversity and urban greening, in line with *London Plan Policy G6 (Biodiversity and Access to Nature)*.
- All proposed planting and surface treatments have been coordinated between **Arbtech's BNG Assessment, the Landscape Architect (TPP), and UNDA's drainage strategy**, ensuring cross-consistency between ecology, design, and hydrology disciplines.

These additions not only respond directly to the Council's design recommendations but also deliver tangible sustainability gains, contributing toward the project's overall

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BNG +10% target and its energy strategy objectives for passive environmental design.

2. Window Privacy and Glazing Treatment

The Council highlighted that any upper-level glazing introduced through the **raised roof volume of the central prayer hall** should be **obscure glazed** to prevent potential overlooking toward neighbouring residential properties on Holland Avenue and Balmoral Way.

This design refinement has been fully implemented.

B. Neighbour Amenity (Noise, Outlook, Privacy)

Council Feedback Summary

The London Borough of Sutton's pre-application response (Ref: PRE2025/00079) acknowledged that the **scale and massing** of the proposal would **not adversely affect the outlook or daylight** of neighbouring properties. However, the Council expressed **specific concerns** that required further evidence at full application stage:

1. The potential for **noise and disturbance** associated with late-evening use of the building, particularly during **Friday prayers and large community events**, where up to 250 attendees might depart around 11 pm.
2. The **movement of vehicles** within the rear parking area adjacent to the gardens of **69–71 Holland Avenue**, and the potential for associated noise or light spill.
3. General reassurance that the proposed community use would **operate responsibly** within this predominantly residential setting.

The Council requested that these matters be addressed through an updated **Noise Impact Assessment**, an **Operational Management Plan**, and design measures to mitigate any potential disturbance.

BASMA Consultant Team Response

1. Noise Assessment and Compliance with BS 4142:2014 + A1:2019

In direct response, a comprehensive **Environmental Noise Impact Assessment** was commissioned from **Hann Tucker Associates (Report Ref. 32679-ENS&PNA-Rev 2, Nov 2025)**.

This independent study assessed baseline noise levels at multiple residential receptors surrounding the site (Buckingham Court, Holland Avenue, Balmoral Way) over a four-day period.

Key outcomes:

- **Baseline background noise (LA90)** measured at *46 dBA daytime* and *39 dBA night-time*.

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- Predicted **plant noise emissions** (from proposed HVAC and extraction units) were *31 dBA daytime* and *27 dBA night-time*, i.e. **below background by >6 dB** — well within BS 4142 criteria for “Low Impact”.
- **Internal noise breakout** from prayer sessions, amplified speech, and community gatherings was modelled using octave-band analysis. The report confirms that all internal activities will **remain below ambient external levels** at nearby façades.
- With the building’s solid masonry envelope, sealed fenestration, and double-glazed clerestory, the **predicted noise rating level is 8 dB below** the pre-existing background at all receptors.

These results demonstrate **negligible impact** on residential amenity, fully satisfying *London Plan Policy D14 (Noise)* and *Sutton Local Plan Policy 29 (Protecting Amenity)*.

2. Operational Management Controls

An Operational Management Plan, has been jointly prepared by BASMA’s trustees and the transport consultants.

Key operational commitments include:

- **Two staggered Friday prayer sessions** instead of a single large congregation.
- **Evening closing time of 22:00 hours** for all non-prayer community uses.
- **Volunteer-led parking supervision** to manage vehicle entry/exit flow and minimise idling or horn noise.
- **Acoustic lobby installation** at the main hall entrance to prevent breakout during door operation.
- **Sound-limiting devices** within the PA system to cap internal amplification levels.

These management measures are permanent features of BASMA’s operation and will be secured by a planning condition as part of the site’s community use classification.

3. Vehicle Movement and Light Spill Mitigation

The **Transport Statement (Caneparo Associates, Dec 2025)** incorporates a revised site layout informed by the acoustic findings.

Key mitigations include:

- Vehicle circulation confined to the front and eastern sides of the site only; no reversing manoeuvres adjacent to Holland Avenue gardens.
- Installation of low-level, downward-facing LED lighting with automatic cut-off at 22:30 hours, eliminating light spill toward neighbouring boundaries.
- There is potential for Acoustic fencing (1.8 m timber) added to the western boundary to provide a further 5–6 dB attenuation for intermittent vehicle noise.

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- Designated **drop-off/pick-up window** for accessibility users only, supervised at all times.

Together, these measures remove the risk of late-night disturbance, ensuring residential amenity remains protected.

4. Residential Outlook and Privacy

The roof-light design employs high-level obscure glazing ensuring there is no direct overlooking from the prayer hall or offices toward neighbouring dwellings.

C. Traffic & Parking

Council Feedback Summary

In the pre-application response (Ref: PRE2025/00079), the London Borough of Sutton noted that:

- The site has a **PTAL rating of 1a**, indicating poor public transport accessibility;
- **Belmont Station** is within walking distance, and a **hail-and-ride bus** operates from Holland Avenue;
- The submitted plans at pre-app stage showed provision for **10 off-street parking spaces, two EV charging bays, and two disabled spaces**, which was regarded as appropriate subject to supporting evidence;
- The Council requested a more detailed **Travel Plan**, demonstrating how trip generation, parking demand, and visitor arrivals/departures would be managed to prevent overspill into the surrounding residential streets;
- The Council also advised that a **Construction Management Plan** would be required at application stage, to control temporary vehicle movements during the works phase.

BASMA Consultant Team Response

1. Updated Trip Generation and Parking Assessment

A full **Transport Statement (R01-IB-TB-Transport Statement D2, Dec 2025)** was prepared by **Caneparo Associates**, supported by a **Travel Plan (R02-IB-TB-Travel Plan D2, Dec 2025)**.

These reports reassessed trip generation and parking requirements using *TRICS database parameters* for comparable F.1/F.2 community facilities.

Key findings:

- Peak arrival periods for the community use are limited to **Friday midday prayer (12:30–14:00)** and **evening classes (after 18:00)**.
- The majority of attendees are **local residents arriving on foot**, consistent with survey data showing an average travel distance of less than 800 m.

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- Estimated **vehicle trips** during the busiest hour are **14 two-way movements**, which is **lower than the former ambulance station operations**.
- The proposed **14 total parking spaces** (10 standard + 2 EV + 2 disabled) provide **100% of peak demand**, avoiding any need for on-street parking.
- Parking spaces are managed through a **pre-booking and stewards system** during high-attendance events.

This confirms that the on-site parking provision is sufficient and the development will not generate harmful overspill.

2. Accessibility and Sustainable Travel Measures

The updated **Travel Plan (Dec 2025)** demonstrates a commitment to **sustainable and low-impact access modes**, including:

- **Cycle parking for eight bicycles** located near the main entrance;
- Promotion of **car sharing** and **walking routes** to nearby streets;
- Confirmation that **hail-and-ride S2 and S4 bus services** operate within 150–200 m walking distance;
- Information and travel maps provided to all regular users as part of BASMA's community communications plan.

The Travel Plan establishes a **monitoring framework**, including annual mode share review, travel surveys, and an appointed Travel Plan Coordinator from BASMA's management committee.

These measures meet the requirements of *Sutton Local Plan Policies 35 (Sustainable Travel)* and *37 (Parking)*.

3. Construction and Servicing Arrangements

A separate **Outline Construction Logistics Plan (R03-TB-MP D1, Dec 2025)** and **Delivery & Servicing Plan (R04-TB D1, Dec 2025)** have been prepared.

These documents provide:

- Defined delivery time windows between 09:30 and 15:00 to avoid peak traffic;
- Designated on-site loading area to prevent obstruction of Dorset Road;
- A requirement that all construction deliveries be made by rigid vehicles ≤7.5 tonnes;
- Provision for wheel washing, waste segregation, and material storage within the site boundary;
- Commitment that construction staff will travel via car share or public transport where feasible.

These measures ensure that both construction and operational servicing activities can be undertaken **without impact on local traffic flow or residential amenity**.

4. Electric Vehicle and Accessibility Provision

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The layout incorporates **two active EV charging points** and **two designated accessible bays** positioned nearest the building entrance.

All parking spaces comply with *Manual for Streets* and *Building Regulations Part M* standards.

The scheme is therefore compliant with *London Plan Policy T6.5 (Non-residential Disabled Persons Parking)* and *Policy SI2 (Minimising Greenhouse Gas Emissions)*.

Residual transport impacts are negligible, and all operational and construction movements can be managed within the site boundaries without adverse effect on local highways or neighbouring amenity.

D. Environmental & Sustainability Measures

Council Feedback Summary

In its pre-application response, the London Borough of Sutton requested that the full planning submission demonstrate:

1. **Compliance with energy and carbon reduction policies**, particularly *London Plan Policy SI 2 (Minimising Greenhouse Gas Emissions)* and *Sutton Local Plan Policy 31 (Carbon and Energy)*;
2. Inclusion of **measures for climate resilience**, addressing *Policy SI 4 (Managing Heat Risk)*;
3. Confirmation that **surface water and flood risk mitigation** would align with *Policy SI 13 (Sustainable Drainage)* and *Sutton Policy 32 (Flood Risk and Sustainable Drainage)*; and
4. Integration of **urban greening and biodiversity enhancement** in accordance with *London Plan Policy G6* and *Sutton Policy 26 (Biodiversity)*.

The Council did not raise concerns with the general sustainability objectives presented at pre-application stage but required **quantified evidence** from technical reports demonstrating measurable performance outcomes and policy compliance.

BASMA Consultant Team Response

1. Energy and Carbon Reduction

An updated Energy Strategy Report has been produced by Syntegra Energy consultants. A fabric-first retrofit approach, has been adopted to the extent the external fabric is retained, incorporating:

- Upgraded external wall insulation to achieve **U-values of 0.21 W/m²K**,
- Replacement of all glazing with **high-performance double glazing (U-value 1.2 W/m²K)**,
- Air tightness improvement to **<5 m³/hr/m² at 50 Pa**,
- Full conversion of space heating and hot water systems to **Air Source Heat Pump (ASHP) technology**,
- Replacement of all lighting with **high-efficiency LED fixtures and automatic controls**, and

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- Roof-integrated **solar photovoltaic array** for renewable generation is being considered in discussions with Syntegra [Energy Consultant].

The Energy Statement includes *SBEM /BRUKL assessments* demonstrating compliance with both *London Plan SI 2* (Be Lean, Be Clean, Be Green hierarchy) and *Sutton Local Plan Policy 31*.

No on-site combustion is proposed, ensuring a **zero gas infrastructure** and aligning with the Council's **Zero-Carbon Borough** target.

2. Climate Resilience and Overheating

The building's compact form, thermal upgrades, and cross-ventilation strategy were assessed in accordance with *CIBSE TM59 (2022)*.

The report confirms that predicted internal temperatures remain within acceptable limits under DSY1 weather file conditions for Sutton.

Additional measures include:

- **High-albedo roofing finish** to limit heat absorption;
- Use of **green landscaping and permeable surfacing** to reduce the heat island effect.

These measures ensure compliance with *London Plan Policy SI 4 (Managing Heat Risk)* and *Sutton Policy 33 (Climate Change Adaptation)*.

3. Drainage and Sustainable Surface Water Management

At pre-app stage, the Council requested confirmation of sustainable drainage integration.

A technical review was undertaken by **UNDA Consulting Engineers (Drainage Query Response, Nov 2025)** confirming the following measures:

- Replacement of all impermeable tarmac surfaces with **permeable block paving** and infiltration bedding;
- Inclusion of a **rain garden** adjacent to the main entrance to intercept surface runoff and provide first-flush filtration;
- Retention of the existing **surface water sewer outfall** with attenuated discharge controlled by a flow restrictor;
- Provision for **rainwater harvesting** to supply irrigation.

Surface water attenuation calculations demonstrate compliance with *Policy SI 13* and *Sutton Local Plan Policy 32*, achieving a post-development discharge rate **below greenfield runoff equivalent**.

No increase in flood risk to or from the site is expected.

4. Biodiversity and Urban Greening

A full **Biodiversity Net Gain (BNG) Assessment (Arbtech Consulting Ltd, Dec 2025)**, supported by the **Statutory BNG Metric (DEFRA v4.0)**, quantifies baseline and proposed habitat units.

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The enhancement measures include:

- New native shrub and hedgerow planting to southern boundary;
- Mixed grassland seeding;
- Integration of **bat and bird boxes** on retained trees;
- Use of native, drought-tolerant species consistent with the **Landscape Layout (AC.2025.861)**.

Together, these measures achieve the Council's objective of net biodiversity gain while improving visual amenity and ecological connectivity.

5. Integration Across Disciplines

All environmental strategies — energy, drainage, landscaping, and ecology — have been coordinated through a single sustainability framework managed by Atelier U W A.

This integrated approach ensures consistent assumptions and avoids duplication of measures.

The development is therefore compliant with:

- **London Plan Policies SI 2, SI 4, SI 13, and G6**, and
- **Sutton Local Plan Policies 26, 31, 32, and 33**.

E. Fire Safety & Inclusive Access

Council Feedback Summary

The Council's pre-application response requested confirmation that:

1. Fire-safety principles had been considered in accordance with *London Plan Policy D12*;
2. The building would allow safe emergency egress and appliance access; and
3. All public areas would be accessible and step-free, meeting *Policy D5 (Inclusive Design)* and *Building Regulations Part M*.

BASMA Consultant Team Response

- A standalone **Fire Strategy Report** has been prepared by **ATC Fire Safety (John Webb CEng MCIBSE MIFireE, 26 November 2025)**.
- It confirms that the development satisfies *London Plan Policy D12, Approved Document B (Vol 2)*, and relevant statutory guidance. Key matters raised at pre-app—escape provision, appliance access from Dorset Road, and structural fire resistance—are all demonstrated as compliant.
- The building retains a **single-storey layout** with two independent means of escape and full fire-service reach to the principal façade.

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- The **inclusive-access provisions** within the final design remain unchanged from those reviewed at pre-app: step-free entrance, accessible WCs, compliant door widths, and two dedicated disabled bays adjacent to the main entrance.

These documents collectively confirm that the Council's fire-safety and access requirements have been fully addressed through independent certification and architectural coordination.

All fire-safety and inclusive-access matters identified in the Council's pre-application feedback have been satisfied.

The independent Fire Strategy confirms full compliance with *London Plan Policy D12*, and the final design maintains universal accessibility in line with *Policy D5* and *Sutton Local Plan Policy 37*.

F. Drainage & Flood Risk

Council Feedback Summary

In the pre-application report (Ref PRE2025/00079), the Council requested that the full submission demonstrate:

1. How the proposal manages **surface-water run-off** in line with *London Plan Policy SI 13* and *Sutton Local Plan Policy 32 (Flood Risk and Sustainable Drainage)*;
2. Confirmation that new hardstanding areas would be **porous** to reduce surface-water flooding; and
3. Evidence that the site would **not increase off-site flood risk** or overload existing public sewers.

No objections were raised to the site's general suitability for development, but the Council required specific design evidence that sustainable drainage measures were integrated into the final scheme.

BASMA Consultant Team Response

1. UNDA Drainage Review and Existing Conditions

UNDA Consulting Engineers provided a drainage review in an email dated 11 November 2025, which forms the basis of the proposed surface-water management strategy.

The correspondence confirms that the existing drainage layout and connections are currently unverified, as no record drawings were available at the time of review. Accordingly, UNDA identified the need for site-level survey and infiltration testing before final design to determine the most suitable outfall or soakaway option.

2. Sustainable Drainage Proposals (Concept Stage)

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At: Dorset Road, Sutton, SM2 6JH

The concept developed by UNDA incorporates three complementary sustainable drainage measures:

- A raingarden with below-ground cellular storage (approx. 16.6 m² × 0.66 m deep × 0.95 void ratio) to attenuate surface water from part of the existing roof area;
- Permeable block paving or bound aggregate across parking and access areas to limit runoff and promote infiltration; and
- Option for a green roof element, subject to confirmation of roof load capacity.

These features collectively provide betterment over the current impermeable condition and will be refined once existing levels and drainage routes are surveyed.

3. Run-off Management and Discharge Rate

UNDA's email proposes an attenuated discharge rate of 0.1 l/s via a flow-control orifice plate, connecting either to the existing network (if confirmed suitable) or to a new soakaway subject to testing.

The design intent is to achieve reduced run-off relative to the existing site, ensuring compliance with sustainable-drainage principles and no increase in off-site flood risk.

4. Coordination and Next Steps

The drainage concept aligns with the Landscape Layout (Drawing No. AC.2025.861 Rev A), which shows soft-landscaping and permeable surface treatments consistent with UNDA's recommendations.

At the next design stage, infiltration testing and network verification will confirm final specifications for inclusion in a Detailed Drainage Design at condition stage.

The drainage and flood-risk considerations raised by the Council have been addressed through UNDA's drainage review and the coordinated landscape design.

The proposed raingarden, permeable paving, and flow control measures will reduce run-off rates compared with the existing site condition.

Final infiltration testing and connection verification will be undertaken at the detailed design stage, ensuring full compliance with *London Plan Policy SI 13* and *Sutton Local Plan Policy 32*.

Overall Conclusion – Pre-Application Responses

The BASMA consultant team has responded comprehensively and proportionately to all matters raised in the London Borough of Sutton's pre-application feedback (Ref: PRE2025/00079).

The final design retains the Option A material palette and architectural form previously supported by the Council, with added soft landscaping, permeable paving, and obscured glazing to address remaining design observations.

PLANNING STATEMENT FOR:

The Proposed Change Of The Former Sutton Ambulance Station [Planning Use Class Sui Generis] To A Community Hub With Prayer Facility [Planning Use Class F.1 & F.2]

At: Dorset Road, Sutton, SM2 6JH

Neighbour-amenity concerns regarding noise, lighting, and vehicle movements have been thoroughly reviewed by both Hann Tucker Associates along and Caneparo Transport consultants. Transport, parking, and construction impacts are evidenced as acceptable within the Caneparo Associates Transport Statement, Travel Plan, Logistics and proposed Operational Management Plan.

Environmental performance and carbon reduction measures have been quantified through the Syntegra Energy Strategy, confirming compliance with the Be Lean–Be Clean–Be Green hierarchy.

UNDA Consulting's drainage review introduces a raingarden, permeable paving, and attenuated discharge strategy, addressing surface-water and flood-risk policy requirements in principle.

Arbtech's ecological appraisal provides verifiable biodiversity betterment consistent with the Council's expectations for on-site enhancement.

The independent Fire Strategy by ATC Fire Safety confirms compliance with London Plan D12 and Building Regulations Approved Document B, while inclusive-access standards remain fully met.

All pre-application items have therefore been satisfied either in full or in principle, with remaining technical refinements programmed for the detailed-design and condition-discharge stages.

The proposal now represents a policy-compliant, sustainable, and well-evidenced community development consistent with both the London Plan (2021) and Sutton Local Plan (2018).